

# SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU



Sky하늘

SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

# SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*A Countdown of Memories and Goodbyes*

by

Sky하늘

2026

Sky하늘

SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

## Seven Days Before I Forget You

Copyright © 2026 Sky하늘

All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced,  
stored, or transmitted in any form without prior  
written permission from the copyright owner,  
except for brief quotations used in reviews.

This is a work of fiction and reflection.

Any resemblance to actual persons or events  
is purely coincidental.

First Edition

Malaysia

## **A Gentle Note**

This story deals with memory loss, emotional detachment, the ache of holding onto fading relationships, and the quiet weight of unsaid farewells.

As the days count down, you will encounter the disorientation of forgetting, the sting of grief, and the struggle to protect what matters before it disappears completely. While these pages mirror emotions that may feel intensely personal, they are not intended to serve as therapeutic or medical advice for cognitive health, trauma, or emotional crisis.

If tracing this countdown weighs heavily on you, allow yourself to step back and breathe. Letting go of a memory does not mean you have to carry the silence alone—reaching out for support is never a defeat.

Thank you for choosing to walk through these final seven days.

Be gentle with your own memories as you turn the page.

## **Before You Begin**

You are not just reading a story; you are witnessing someone's world slip through their fingers, hour by hour.

This countdown is measured not by clocks, but by the quiet disappearance of shared jokes, familiar voices, and the certainty of who was once loved. Some chapters will feel sharp and sudden. Others will carry the slow, hollow ache of a room emptying out in the dark.

Do not rush these seven days. When the fog sets in, let it linger. When a forgotten detail resurfaces, give it the silence it deserves. And if you recognize pieces of your own unsaid goodbyes buried in these pages, pause and take a breath before you turn to tomorrow.

We cannot stop the clock, and we cannot force what slips away to stay.

All we can do is hold the light for as long as it lasts.

**Welcome to Day Seven.**

## Contents

|                                 |     |
|---------------------------------|-----|
| Day 1 — THE FIRST MEETING ..... | 2   |
| DAY 2 — THE FREQUENCY .....     | 8   |
| DAY 3 — THE FIRST MARK .....    | 17  |
| DAY 4 — THE COVENANT .....      | 24  |
| DAY 5 — THE RUPTURE .....       | 31  |
| DAY 6 — THE CONTOUR.....        | 38  |
| DAY 7 — THE CLEAN SLATE .....   | 47  |
| THE SOMATIC ARCHIVE .....       | 54  |
| THE PHANTOM INVENTORY.....      | 63  |
| SOMATIC DRIFT .....             | 70  |
| THE LEDGER OF PRIDE .....       | 77  |
| THE FRAYING EDGE.....           | 84  |
| THE BROKEN SENTRY.....          | 91  |
| THE RETURN TO ST. JUDE .....    | 99  |
| AN UNLOCKED DOOR.....           | 108 |
| THE EXHIBITION .....            | 114 |
| THE SILHOUETTE.....             | 121 |
| THE CORNER BOOTH .....          | 128 |
| THE THRESHOLD .....             | 137 |
| DAY ZERO .....                  | 145 |

## CHAPTER 1

### **Day 1 — THE FIRST MEETING**

The kettle was screaming its thin, tinny note before Evan realized he had been staring into an empty mug for three full minutes.

The kitchen smelled of burnt toast and wet pavement. Outside the narrow window of their fourth-floor flat, the late September rain was coming down in steady, gray sheets, turning the brick facades across the street into dark, sodden slabs. It was eight in the morning on a Sunday, the one hour of the week that was supposed to belong strictly to them.

"Evan?"

Clara's voice came from the small dining table behind him, soft and rough with sleep. She was wearing his oversized gray wool cardigan, the cuffs rolled twice over her wrists, her bare feet tucked under her thighs on the worn wooden chair. She was buttering a corner of sourdough with methodical patience, her hair pinned up loosely with a tortoiseshell clip that was missing one tooth.

"Tea's almost done," Evan said, his voice coming out flatter than he intended. He switched off the stove, poured the boiling water over the leaves, and watched the dark amber swirl rise in the ceramic pot.

He brought the tray over and set it between them. He sat down, reaching automatically for the strawberry jam, following the domestic choreography they had rehearsed a thousand times over the last five years. He knew the weight of the ceramic mugs. He knew she took half a sugar and barely a

splash of milk. He knew the slight dip in the floorboards between the counter and the table.

Then Clara looked up from her plate, her dark eyes catching the pale light filtering through the rain. A faint, conspiratorial smile touched the corner of her mouth.

"I had that dream again," she said.

Evan paused with his mug halfway to his lips. "The one with the train?"

"No," she said, leaning forward on her elbows, her chin resting in the cup of her palm. "The rainy one. You, standing under that rusted green awning with that ridiculous yellow umbrella that had two broken ribs. Do you remember what you told the woman with the wet dog while we were waiting for the tram?"

Evan took a slow sip of hot tea. The heat scalded the tip of his tongue.

"Remind me," he murmured, smiling back. It was his default defense, a harmless reflex he used when he hadn't had his second cup of coffee or when a work deadline was chewing at his peripheral vision.

"You really don't remember?" Clara chuckled, shaking her head. "You told her the tram was probably on strike because even the rails looked depressed. And then you offered half of your broken umbrella to a golden retriever that hated you on sight."

She laughed, looking down into her mug.

Evan didn't laugh.

Beneath the steady hum of the rain against the glass, something cold and metallic tightened around the base of his skull. He stared at Clara's



profile—the small mole beneath her left collarbone, the curve of her jaw, the way her fringe parted unevenly.

He waited for the image to click into place. He waited for the rusted green awning. The tram rails shining in the wet dark. The smell of wet dog fur. The ridiculous yellow umbrella.

Nothing happened.

The space in his mind where the memory should have lived was not dark, and it was not fuzzy. It was simply not there. It felt like walking into a room in his own home and finding that a wall had been replaced by sheer, empty air.

*Think*, he told himself, the muscles in his forearms locking against the wood of the table. *Where was that tram stop? Which city? Was it by the canal or near the central library?*

Nothing. There was no tram. There was no awning. He knew, with absolute certainty, that he had lived thirty-one years on this earth. He could recall the name of his third-grade teacher. He could recite the license plate of his uncle's battered blue sedan from fifteen years ago. He could remember the exact bitter taste of the medicine he drank during a bout of pneumonia when he was seven.

Yet he could not produce a single second of the hour he met the woman sitting three feet away from him.

"Evan?"

Clara was looking at him now, the smile gone from her face, replaced by that quiet, scrutinizing tilt of her head she used when she suspected he was hiding a fever or an unpaid invoice.

"You look pale," she said, her fingers extending across the table to brush the back of his hand. Her skin was warm, familiar, grounded in real bone and blood. "Are you okay? You've been working those twelve-hour shifts all week. Did you sleep at all?"

"Yeah," he heard himself say. His voice sounded distant, like it was traveling through a long cardboard tube. "Just... woke up with a weird headache. Behind the eyes."

"Drink the tea," she urged gently, pulling her hand back to wrap it around her own mug. "We don't have anywhere to go today. We can just stay in."

"Right. Nowhere to go."

He forced a small, practiced nod, raised the mug to his mouth, and swallowed the rest of the scalding liquid without tasting it.

Twenty minutes later, when the shower pipes in the bathroom began their rhythmic, vibrating rattle, Evan slipped out of his chair. He didn't go to the medicine cabinet for paracetamol.

He walked into the hallway, pulled on his damp windbreaker, grabbed his wallet from the side table, and stepped out into the stairwell.

He didn't take the lift. He ran down the concrete steps two at a time, his boots slapping loudly against the landings, his chest hitching with sudden, ragged breaths. He pushed through the glass lobby doors into the downpour without an umbrella, barely feeling the ice-cold rain soaking through the shoulders of his jacket.

He crossed the street and ducked into the dry, fluorescent glare of the twenty-four-hour newsagent on the corner. The bell above the door gave a dull *ping*. The clerk behind the counter, an older man with wire-rimmed glasses reading the Sunday paper, barely looked up.

Evan walked straight to the back aisle where the dusty school supplies hung on wire pegs.

His hand was shaking so badly he knocked a row of cheap ballpoint pens to the floor before his fingers closed around what he was looking for: a thick, black, hardback notebook with an elastic band, completely devoid of branding or lines. Just plain, stark white paper.

He threw a ten-dollar note on the counter, didn't wait for the change, and turned back toward the door.

Back inside the apartment lobby, standing out of the wind beside the brass mailboxes, Evan tore off the plastic wrap with his teeth. He pressed the notebook against the cold metal surface of the wall, clicked his pen, and opened to the first blank page.

At the top, his handwriting was jagged, sharp with an adrenaline he couldn't name:

**OCTOBER 4. DAY 1.**

Beneath it, he paused. His breath fogged against the dark paint of the foyer. Then he wrote:

*Her name is Clara.*

*She is twenty-nine years old.*

*She takes half a spoon of sugar in her black tea.*

*She wears my gray wool cardigan when the morning is cold.*

*She says we met at a tram stop in the rain under a green awning.*

*I have no idea what she is talking about.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

He stared at the ink as it sank into the porous white paper. He closed the book, pulled the black elastic tight over the cover, and stood in the dim stairwell, listening to the rain pound the roof above him, waiting for the terror to make sense.

## CHAPTER 2

### **DAY 2 — THE FREQUENCY**

For six days, the notebook lived in the inside breast pocket of Evan's jacket, resting directly over his ribs like a concealed weapon.

He treated it like an anchor. Every night while Clara slept, he sat at the edge of the mattress under the blue glare of his phone screen, adding lines to the ledger. He cataloged everything he could see, touch, or verify: the chipped mint-green mug she always claimed first, the scar across the knuckle of her left index finger from an old framing knife, the way she took her tea with half a teaspoon of sugar and barely enough milk to cloud the surface.

If memory was failing him, empirical data would take its place.

By Friday, he had almost convinced himself that the incident at the breakfast table had been a fluke—a transient ischemic attack, severe exhaustion from a sixty-hour workweek, or just the kind of benign brain fog that comes with entering your thirties. He had walked past the corner of 4th and Elm twice on his lunch break, looking at the rusted tram rails, forcing the image of a green awning to surface. It never did. But he had memorized the street name now. If she brought it up again, he could recite the coordinates like a script. He could perform the role of a man who remembered.

Then Saturday night bled into Sunday morning.

The transition happened without fanfare. No thunder, no sudden spike of migraine, no dramatic blackout. Just the digital red numbers on the bedside clock flipping quietly from 11:59 PM to 12:00 AM.

Evan had stayed awake deliberately, propped up against the headboard, his eyes burning as he watched the red digits change. Clara was curled on her side beside him, breathing with the slow, rhythmic cadence of someone who believed the ground beneath her was entirely solid.

When the zero appeared, Evan felt a faint sensation behind his temples—not pain, but a brief, dull suction, like the sudden depressurization of an airplane cabin when the heavy door seals shut.

He waited. He squeezed his eyes closed, testing his faculties. His name was Evan Vance. He was thirty-one. His mother lived four hours north in a brick bungalow. His bank balance ended in .42. Clara was asleep two inches from his hip.

Everything was intact.

He let out a long, ragged breath, slid down beneath the duvet, and finally let sleep take him.

The sun was bright and brittle when he woke at nine. The rain from the previous week had scrubbed the city sky into a sharp, cold blue.

From the living room came the low, mechanical click of the turntable needle settling into a vinyl groove, followed by the familiar, crackling hiss of dust against a stylus. Then, music filled the small apartment.

It was an acoustic guitar, picked slowly, accompanied by an old cello that sounded like wood groaning under water. A woman's voice came in—raspy, close to the microphone, singing about salt water and winter coats.

Clara was standing by the bookshelf, barefoot, wearing high-waisted linen trousers and a faded navy jumper. She was swaying slightly to the tempo, her eyes closed, humming the melody under her breath.

When she heard his bare feet against the floorboards, she opened her eyes. The expression on her face was open, tender, unguarded—the kind of look reserved for private rooms and shared histories.

"Morning," she whispered over the chorus. "You slept late."

"Yeah," Evan said, leaning against the doorframe of the hallway. "Must've needed it."

She gestured toward the spinning record with her coffee mug, smiling as the cello swelled into a minor chord. "I dug this out of the bottom crate. We haven't played it since the move. Remember when the power went out during the storm two summers ago, and we kept rewinding this exact track on your laptop until the battery died?"

Evan looked at the black vinyl spinning on the turntable.

He listened to the notes. He heard the guitar, the strings vibrating against the fretboard. He recognized the time signature—three-four time. He could understand the English words coming from the speaker.

But it was just noise.

It had no weight. It had no context. It sat in his ears the way background chatter in an airport waiting lounge sat: audible, real, and completely detached from his soul.

*Remember when the power went out?*

He stared at the turntable. He searched for the dark room. He searched for the glow of the laptop screen. He searched for the feeling of sitting shoulder-to-shoulder on the floor while the rain hammered the balcony.

There was nothing. Not even a silhouette. The entire event had been clipped out of his timeline with surgical precision.

Worse, he looked at Clara's face—the soft expectation lingering in the corners of her eyes—and realized with a sickening lurch in his stomach that he didn't even know the name of the band.

"Evan?"

The smile slipped from her face. It didn't vanish into anger; it eroded into confusion, the same subtle fracture he had seen seven days ago over the tea tray.

"You really don't know this song?" she asked. Her voice dropped an octave, losing its playfulness. "It's track three. You bought the pressing in that cellar shop behind the market. You said..." She stopped, setting the mug down on the edge of the shelf with a sharp *clack*. "You told me it was the only song that ever made sense of leaving home."

Evan's mouth went dry. His pulse was a deafening roar in his ears, louder than the cello, louder than the turntable.

The pattern was real.

Last Sunday, it was the origin. This Sunday, it was the anthem.

His mind wasn't decaying. It wasn't succumbing to some chaotic, random rot that took names and dates at random. It was dismantling their life systematically, peeling off the layers from the outside in.



"Of course I know it," Evan lied. The words tasted like ash. He stepped forward, forcing his shoulders to drop, forcing his mouth into a tired, easy grin. "Sorry. I'm just... still half asleep. The bridge is coming up, right?"

Clara didn't answer right away. She stood entirely still, studying his face with a piercing, clinical focus that made him feel naked. She wasn't just looking at him; she was searching for the man who had bought that record, wondering why a stranger was answering from behind his eyes.

"The bridge was two minutes ago, Evan," she said quietly.

She reached out, lifted the tonearm, and cut the music mid-measure. The sudden silence that dropped over the living room was deafening. The only sound left was the low hum of the refrigerator from the kitchen.

"I have to go into the studio," she said, her tone suddenly brisk, practical, and thoroughly guarded. She picked up her bag from the armchair without looking at him. "There's a print run that needs checking before tomorrow."

"Clara—"

"Eat something," she said, reaching for her coat by the door. "You look hollow."

The lock clicked shut behind her.

Evan didn't move until her footsteps faded down the stairwell. The moment the outer door banged shut downstairs, he bolted into the bedroom.

He didn't grab the notebook this time. Instead, he went straight to his desk—an old oak writing bureau he had dragged up the stairs three years ago. The bottom right drawer had been stuck for as long as he could remember; he had always assumed the wood had swollen from the damp autumns.

He gripped the brass handle and pulled. It held fast.

He yanked harder, bracing his boot against the baseboard. The wood groaned, splintered slightly along the seam, and gave way with a violent crack.

Inside, there were no loose papers. There were no spare keys, no receipts, no dust.

Neatly arranged in two parallel rows were seven micro-cassette tapes, each labeled in his own neat, technical block lettering using a black felt-tip pen:

**01 – ARRIVAL**

**02 – THE SOUND**

**03 – THE FIRST MARK**

**04 – THE COVENANT**

**05 – THE RUPTURE**

**06 – THE CONTOUR**

**07 – THE CLEAN SLATE**

Resting beside the plastic cases was a heavy, silver Olympus handheld micro-cassette recorder, its battery indicator glowing with a fresh red light. Taped to the metallic casing of the recorder was a small yellow square of paper.

The handwriting on the note was undeniably his own:

*If you are looking for the song, it's track three on the second tape.  
Don't play it. You spent four months earning this silence. Stop tearing  
open the stitches.*

Evan did not breathe.

The yellow Post-it note seemed to vibrate under the flat white light of the bedroom. The ink was dry, the adhesive still sharp. It had not been left there years ago by some forgotten version of himself; the paper was crisp, unyellowed, placed with calculated precision.

*You spent four months earning this silence. Stop tearing open the stitches.*

His thumb hovered over the silver casing of the recorder. His instinct screamed at him to slam the drawer shut, throw the deadbolt, and run out into the cold midday air until his lungs gave out. But terror has its own gravity.

He picked up the cassette labeled **02 – THE SOUND.**

The plastic was cold against his palm. He slid the tape into the slot on top of the Olympus recorder. The mechanical latch snapped shut with a hollow, plastic *clack* that echoed like a shot in the quiet flat.

He didn't press play. Not yet.

Instead, he walked back to the kitchen counter, dragged the black hardback notebook from his jacket, and laid it open beside the recorder. His pen was already uncapped. His hand was trembling so violently that the first stroke tore a minute gash into the paper.

He forced himself to steady his wrist against the laminate surface, etching the second entry into the ledger:

**OCTOBER 11. DAY 2.**

*Her favorite song is track three.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*It features an acoustic guitar and a cello that sounds like groaning timber.*

*She says we listened to it during a blackout two summers ago until the laptop died.*

*To me, it is just friction against a wire. There is no blackout. There is no summer.*

*I found the drawer.*

*Seven tapes. My handwriting.*

*The note says I bought this silence.*

*The note says I am the one holding the scalpel.*

*If I did this to myself, what did she do to make me want to forget?*

*Or what did I do to her?*

Evan set the pen down. The silence of the apartment was suffocating now, heavy with the phantom traces of an argument he couldn't remember and a grief he hadn't yet felt.

He picked up the silver recorder, brought it to his ear, and pressed the black **PLAY** button.

The motor whirred, a quiet, churning hiss of magnetic tape passing over the head. Static spilled out—hollow, distant room noise.

Then came the sound of a throat clearing. A lighter striking. The sharp intake of breath.

When the voice spoke, it was low, exhausted, and unmistakably his own.

*"Don't look at her like that,"* his past self said, the voice flat and devoid of warmth. *"I know the face you're making right now. You're standing in the*

*kitchen, wondering why the record sounded like dead air. You're terrified that you're losing your mind."*

A short, bitter pause. The sound of smoke being blown away from the microphone.

*"You're not losing your mind, Evan. You're finally getting rid of hers."*

*You asked for this protocol because by the end, every single chord in that flat felt like glass under your skin. You couldn't sit in the same room with her without choking on what we became. The clinic told us the emotional decay would follow the sensory anchors first. The places. Then the music. Next Sunday, it's the third tape."*

The voice lowered, turning razor-sharp.

*"Put the recorder back in the drawer. Don't go digging through old texts. Don't try to look for the letters in the wardrobe. If you make her fall in love with you again just because you're too cowardly to handle the emptiness, you will destroy what little dignity she has left."*

*Let her leave, Evan. Let the week run out."*

A sharp *click* severed the tape. The motor hummed in reverse for a split second, then fell dead.

Evan stood frozen in the gray light of the kitchen, the recorder pressed hard against his ear, staring at the empty space by the bookshelf where the turntable sat in absolute silence.

## CHAPTER 3

### DAY 3 — THE FIRST MARK

The week between the second and third tape passed like a slow bleed.

Evan stopped sleeping. If he closed his eyes, he feared the clock would skip ahead, robbing him of days he hadn't yet accounted for. Instead, he stayed awake in the dark, watching the red digital glow of the bedside clock pulse against the wall, listening to Clara's slow, steady breathing.

He didn't touch her. Every time her shoulder brushed his arm under the duvet, a cold pang of guilt lodged in his throat.

*If you make her fall in love with you again just because you're too cowardly to handle the emptiness, you will destroy what little dignity she has left.*

The words from the second tape played on a relentless loop in his skull. His own voice had sounded so clinical, so unforgiving. He had spoken of her like an infection he had paid good money to cut out. But looking at her in the morning light—the faint blue veins tracing her temples, the quiet concentration with which she tied her hair before leaving for the print studio—he couldn't reconcile the woman in front of him with whatever ruined version of their lives the recording hinted at.

She was gentle. She was careful around him, treating his sudden silence as if it were a fragile recovery from an illness he refused to name. On Thursday, she left a small glass container of steamed dumplings on the stove with a Post-it note stuck to the lid: *Eat before it gets cold. I'll be back late.*

He ate them standing over the sink. Every swallow tasted like theft.

Saturday night arrived with the inevitability of a guillotine.

By eleven o'clock, Clara was already asleep, exhausted from a double shift framing oversized prints. Evan sat at the kitchen table, the third micro-cassette resting on the wood before him.

### 03 – THE FIRST MARK

He checked the time: 11:58 PM.

He didn't need a medical scanner to know what was coming. The pattern had established its rhythm. At midnight, another wire would be snipped.

He gripped the table with both hands, staring at the second hand ticking around the clock face. He tried to build a wall around his own skull. He forced himself to recall every milestone he could dig up: their move into this flat, the broken wardrobe, their holiday by the coast, the day they adopted the stray black cat that ran away three months later.

*Stay*, he thought, his knuckles whitening against the veneer. *Hold*.

The red digits clicked: **12:00 AM**.

The sensation came immediately. It was not a physical headache. It was the feeling of a heavy book being shut softly in an adjoining room. A door clicking closed. A circuit breaker snapping off in the basement of his subconscious.

Evan sat motionless in the dim yellow light of the stove bulb.

He tested the perimeter.

He remembered her favorite tea. He remembered the name of the band on the vinyl. He remembered that they had lived together for five years.

Then he tried to remember the first time his mouth had ever touched hers.

He reached into the past, reaching for the spark—the sudden hitch in the chest, the smell of her perfume, the rain, the heat, the dark, whatever it had been. He searched for the exact second their lives had crossed the line from acquaintances to lovers.

There was nothing.

He knew that they had kissed thousands of times. He could see the physical act as an abstract concept—two people closing the distance between their faces. But the *origin*, the definitive first mark of their intimacy, had been reduced to a blank white wall. It held no heat, no memory, no texture. It was an entry in an encyclopedia that someone had struck through with black ink.

He dropped his head into his palms, pressing his thumbs into his eye sockets until colors bloomed against the dark.

"Why?" he whispered into the empty kitchen. "What did we do?"

At seven in the morning, Clara emerged from the bedroom.

She was wrapped in an old navy dressing gown, her feet dragging against the floorboards. She looked exhausted, dark shadows bruising the pale skin beneath her eyes. She walked past him to the stove, filled the kettle, and set it down without turning around.

"You didn't sleep again," she said. It wasn't an accusation; it was a sigh.

"I tried," Evan said from the table.

She stood by the counter, waiting for the water to boil, her back to him. The small kitchen was thick with a heavy, unarticulated dread. She turned



around slowly, leaning her lower back against the sink, looking at him with an intensity that made the breath catch in his throat.

"Evan," she said softly. "Look at me."

He looked up.

She walked over to where he sat. She didn't ask for permission. She placed one hand gently against the side of his neck, her thumb brushing the line of his jaw. Her palm was warm, smelling faintly of linseed oil and cedarwood from the studio.

"We haven't touched in three weeks," she whispered. Her voice trembled, a hairline fracture running through her composure. "You flinch whenever I sit next to you. You look at me like you're trying to solve an equation that doesn't make sense."

She leaned down.

Evan felt the panic surge from his gut straight to his throat. He wanted to lean back, to pull away, to obey the voice on the tape that warned him against tearing the stitches. But he couldn't move. He was pinned by the raw, naked pleading in her dark eyes.

She closed the space between them.

Her lips pressed against his.

It was not a hurried kiss. It was deep, desperate, and laden with the unbearable gravity of someone trying to pull a drowning man out of dark water with her bare mouth.

Evan felt the warmth of her skin. He felt the soft pressure, the slight tremble of her lower lip, the familiar cadence of her breath against his cheek.

And inside his chest, there was only a profound, terrifying silence.

His body did not respond. The emotional nerve had been cut clean through. He was kissing a woman he knew he loved, but it felt like pressing his mouth against a mirror—cold, reflective, and utterly dead.

Clara pulled back.

She didn't scream. She didn't drop her gaze. She simply looked at him, her eyes wide, searching his face for the man who used to hold her like the world was burning down around them.

She saw the void.

A single tear tracked down her cheek, catching the pale morning light, before she stepped back, taking her hand away from his neck as if she had just touched an open wire.

"You're gone," she whispered, her voice barely carrying over the sudden, piercing whistle of the boiling kettle. "You're still sitting in front of me, but you aren't here anymore."

She turned, switched off the stove, and walked straight out of the kitchen. A moment later, the bedroom door clicked shut, and the lock turned from the inside.

Evan didn't wait for her to come out.

He grabbed the black notebook, the silver Olympus recorder, and the third cassette. He walked down the four flights of stairs, past the lobby mailboxes, and stepped into the sharp October cold.

He didn't go to the newsagent. He walked three blocks down to an overgrown concrete park that sat beside the dry railway canal. He sat on a

rusted green bench beneath an alder tree, where the fallen leaves were turning black with rot.

He opened the notebook. His hands were dead steady now—the shaking had stopped, replaced by the grim, mechanical certainty of an autopsy.

He pressed the pen to the page:

**OCTOBER 18. DAY 3.**

*She kissed me this morning.*

*I felt the warmth of her mouth, but the memory of why it ever mattered has been erased.*

*I don't know when our relationship started.*

*I don't know who crossed the room first.*

*She knows.*

*She looked at me and saw the empty space where a person used to be.*

*She locked the bedroom door.*

*If this was an act of mercy, it is the cruellest mercy ever invented.*

*I am going to listen to the third tape now.*

*I don't care what my past self says.*

*If I am a monster, I want to hear the charges read aloud.*

Evan capped the pen, laid the notebook on the rusted wood of the bench, and loaded **03 – THE FIRST MARK** into the Olympus.

He pushed the black plastic button down.

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

The tape hissed. The motor whirred.

Then his own voice spilled through the small metal speaker, sharp as a winter wind:

*"Did she try to kiss you today?"*

## CHAPTER 4

### DAY 4 — THE COVENANT

The voice coming from the Olympus recorder did not sound like a memory. It sounded like an ambush.

*"Did she try to kiss you today?"*

Evan's thumb tightened against the cold plastic casing. The alder leaves above him shuddered in the autumn draft, shedding brittle flakes of black rot onto the bench beside his knee.

On the tape, his past self gave a low, humorless chuckle—the sound of dry gravel grinding under a boot.

*"If she did, I know how it felt. Like kissing a mannequin. Like pressing your mouth to cold glass and pretending you can taste breath.*

*You're sitting somewhere quiet right now, aren't you? Probably down by the canal, looking at the dead rails, wondering how you could be so callous. You're telling yourself that she doesn't deserve this. You're right. She doesn't.*

*The first time we kissed was on the fire escape behind the bakery on 8th Street. November. It was freezing, her fingers smelled like flour and almond extract, and she had just found out her father had six months left. She didn't want comfort. She wanted to feel like something in this city wasn't rotting from the inside out. I pulled her into my coat. I kissed her like I could keep the cold from touching her skin.*

*It was the most arrogant mistake of my life.*

*I thought loving someone meant turning your own ribs into a cage to shield them from the weather. But all I did was trap us both in the dark. By the end, she wasn't living with a man; she was living with a sentry. An anxious, exhausted watchman who couldn't stop looking for the fire.*

*Stop trying to hold the perimeter, Evan. Next Sunday is the ring. Leave it on the counter."*

The tape ended with an abrupt *thunk*. The red indicator light on the recorder went dark.

Evan sat on the rusted slats of the bench, the silence of the canal bank pressing against his eardrums. The air smelled of wet rust and dead foliage.

*A sentry.*

He looked down at his own hands—the blunt knuckles, the faint white crescent scar across his right thumb where an X-Acto knife had slipped during an inventory run years ago. He had spent his entire twenties believing that utility was the highest form of affection. If the bills were cleared, if the deadbolts were oiled, if the pantry was stocked before the winter storms, then he was doing the work of a man.

He had never stopped to ask if anyone actually wanted to live inside the fortress he was building.

He didn't return to the flat until dusk.

When he turned the brass key in the lock, the apartment was dark save for the pale amber strip of light leaking from beneath the bathroom door. The silence wasn't the easy, companionable quiet of two people sharing a domestic space; it was the tense, suspended stillness of a museum after visiting hours, where everything on display was fragile and irreplaceable.

Clara came out of the bathroom ten minutes later.

She had washed her hair; it hung damp and dark over the shoulders of a clean charcoal sweater. Her face was scrubbed raw, the red margins around her eyes betraying the hours she had spent behind the locked bedroom door.

She didn't ask where he had been for seven hours. She didn't look at his windbreaker, damp with river mist.

She walked over to the wooden side table near the entryway, where their mail gathered in a shallow wicker bowl. Without a word, she picked up her key ring—an old brass loop holding three flat apartment keys and a thin, tarnished silver band hanging from a worn leather cord.

She slipped the silver band off the cord.

The metal made a soft, sharp *clink* as she set it on the glass surface of the coffee table between them.

"I found this under the bureau when I was sweeping," she said. Her voice was quiet, stripped of the raw pleading from that morning, replaced by an exhaustion so profound it sounded almost peaceful.

Evan looked down at the band.

It was narrow, hand-hammered, with uneven edges that showed it had been made by an artisan rather than stamped out by a factory machine. On the inside curve, worn smooth against years of skin, was a microscopic engraving:

*Till the tide recedes.*

He reached out. His fingers hovered over the metal for two seconds before he picked it up.

The silver was cold. He rolled it between his thumb and forefinger, waiting for the familiar neural pathway to ignite—waiting for the memory of the shop, the beach, the words spoken over the exchange, the reason they had chosen those specific five words.

Nothing.

The concept was a blank slate. He knew what a ring was; he understood the grammar of a promise. But the emotional covenant that gave the object its sacred weight had been systematically severed. It was just thirty grams of tarnished alloy sitting in the center of his palm.

"Do you know what today is?" Clara asked.

She was standing three paces back, her arms crossed tight against her ribs, holding herself together with an effort that caused her knuckles to turn bone-white under the sweater cuffs.

Evan looked from the ring to her face.

*Day 4.*

The fourth Sunday. The schedule was relentless.

"Tell me," he said. He didn't try to fake the recognition this time. The lie from last week had rotted on his tongue.

A ghost of a smile touched the edge of Clara's mouth—not of amusement, but of a quiet, agonizing surrender.

"Four years ago today," she whispered. "We took that ridiculous ferry to the outer islands. It rained the entire forty-minute crossing. We stood at the bow because you insisted the fresh air would keep me from getting seasick, even though you were the one turning green."



She looked down at the floorboards, tracing a faint water ring with the toe of her wool sock.

"We bought these from that old silversmith working out of a converted cargo container behind the fish market. You told me that promises between people were fragile because people change their minds when the weather turns bad. But the tide..." She swallowed, her throat working against a dry knot. "You said the tide doesn't negotiate with the shore. It pulls away, but it always comes back. You promised me that no matter how far out the water went, you would never leave the beach."

She looked up. Her dark eyes were completely clear, stripped of illusion.

"The water's gone, Evan."

Evan's chest hitched. An invisible fist tightened around his windpipe, squeezing until his vision speckled with black pinpricks. The factual memory was dead, but the animal part of his brain—the primitive, physical organ that recognized loss—rebelled against the emptiness. He wanted to throw his arms around her. He wanted to grab her by the shoulders and scream that he was sorry, that he had made a horrific, catastrophic error in judgment, that he wanted the clinic to reverse the sequence immediately.

*Stop tearing open the stitches.*

His past voice stood between them like an iron bulkhead.

"Clara," he began, his voice cracking on the syllable.

"Don't," she said, raising one flat palm to stop the sentence in mid-air. "Don't recite a line you think you're supposed to say. I've watched you for a month, Evan. You look at me the way people look at an old monument

in a square—you know it has a history, you know it took a long time to build, but you have no idea why it's standing there anymore."

She walked toward the small guest alcove off the kitchen—the narrow room where they stored extra canvases, winter blankets, and the spare folding cot.

She paused at the door, her back to him.

"You don't have to keep the watch anymore," she said quietly. "If the roof is caving in, let it fall. I'm not going to starve in this house just to keep you from feeling guilty."

The door clicked shut.

Evan stood alone in the dim amber light of the living room. The silver band lay heavy in his palm, biting into the flesh of his fingers as his fist clenched tight.

He walked over to the desk, pulled the black hardback notebook from his breast pocket, and laid it beside the Olympus recorder. The drawer was still fractured where he had splintered the lock, the remaining three tapes sitting in their plastic cases like unexploded ordnance.

He uncapped his pen. The entry was brief, jagged, and carved so deep into the page that the paper buckled:

**OCTOBER 25. DAY 4.**

*The ring says: 'Till the tide recedes.'*

*She told me the story. The ferry, the rain, the silversmith in the cargo container.*

*I heard every word.*

*I felt none of them.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*She moved into the spare room tonight.*

*She thinks I fell out of love.*

*She thinks I looked at five years of life and simply decided it was no longer worth the effort.*

*She doesn't know that my past self paid a specialist to hollow out my skull so she could walk away without carrying a corpse.*

*Three weeks left.*

*Tape 05 is labeled 'THE RUPTURE.'*

*Next Sunday, I forget the fight that broke us.*

*I don't know what is more terrifying: the fact that I am forgetting her, or the fact that part of me understands why I wanted to.*

He closed the notebook, set the silver band on top of the black cover, and sat in the dark kitchen until dawn, watching the shadows stretch across the empty chairs.

## CHAPTER 5

### DAY 5 — THE RUPTURE

The silence in the flat was no longer a lack of noise; it had become an architectural element, solid as concrete, sitting between the bedroom and the guest alcove.

They moved around each other like shift workers sharing an industrial berth. Clara woke at six, made her tea, washed her cup, and left for the print studio before the streetlights clicked off. Evan stayed in the bedroom until the heavy front door thudded shut. When he returned from the logistics depot in the evenings, her boots were already by the mat, her door pulled shut with a folded towel tucked beneath the gap to block out the light.

She wasn't angry. Anger required energy, and both of them were running on fumes. She was simply dismantling her presence, thread by thread.

Evan spent the week trying to reconstruct the fight.

Every relationship has a fault line—a moment when the quiet resentment that has been gathering dust in the corners finally catches fire and consumes the living room. If he was going to lose the memory of it on Sunday, he needed to know what his crime had been before the record was wiped clean.

He tore through his desk drawers. He combed through old bank statements, tax filings, text archives on his laptop dating back two years.

There was no record of an affair. No secret debts, no gambled savings, no police reports, no screaming voicemail threads.

Instead, the paper trail revealed something far more banal and far more lethal: a steady, chronological tightening of a noose.

- **March:** Clara's application for an artist residency in Rotterdam, accepted with a full stipend. Attached was a printed confirmation with a handwritten note in the margin in her looping scrawl: *Can we make this work?*
- **April:** A stack of rejected loan applications for Evan's independent logistics venture. Three separate commercial banks, all stamped with the same cold bureaucratic red ink: *Insufficient collateral.*
- **May:** Utility bills showing late fees accumulating on the apartment lease. A medical receipt from the regional hospital for Clara's emergency appendix removal—four thousand dollars, paid in full on Evan's emergency credit card with twenty-four percent compound interest.
- **June:** A draft email in his sent folder to the Rotterdam academy, signed by Clara, withdrawing her acceptance due to "unforeseen personal and familial obligations."

Evan stared at the screen in the dim kitchen, his skin prickling with cold shame.

He hadn't hit her. He hadn't cheated. He had done something worse: he had allowed his own suffocating financial gravity to drag her out of the sky. He had turned his quiet, stubborn pride into a lead weight tied to her ankles, convincing himself all the while that because he was working

seventy hours a week to clear that hospital bill, he was the noble martyr of the story.

Saturday night, 11:55 PM.

Evan didn't wait in the bedroom. He sat on the floor of the hallway, his back pressed against the wall directly outside the guest room door, the Olympus recorder resting between his socks.

Inside the room, the floorboards creaked. Then the latch turned, and the door swung open three inches.

Clara stood in the gap. She was wearing an old flannel shirt that used to belong to him, the hem frayed where it brushed her knees. She didn't look surprised to find him sitting on the floor like a discarded coat.

"What are you doing, Evan?" she asked, her voice dry, barely louder than the hum of the refrigerator.

"Tell me what I said," Evan whispered. He didn't look up at her. He kept his eyes locked on the seam of the floorboards. "In June. When you gave up the residency. Tell me what I said to you in this hallway."

Clara stood motionless. A car passed on the street below, its headlights sweeping across the ceiling in a slow, pale arc.

"Why?" she asked. A bitter edge cut through her exhaustion. "So you can apologize again? So you can tell me how sorry you are that you couldn't be the man I needed, and then spend the next six months punishing yourself by working sixteen-hour night shifts until your hands shake?"

"I need to know," he said, his voice hitching. "Please. Before midnight."

Clara let out a breath that sounded like torn paper. She leaned her forehead against the doorframe, looking down at him with an expression of profound, weary pity.

"You didn't shout, Evan. That was the problem. You never shout."

She pulled the flannel shirt tighter around her shoulders.

"You sat at that table, looked at the invoice from the hospital, and you asked me how I could even think about moving across the ocean when we were four hundred dollars away from an eviction notice. You asked me who was going to pay the rent while I was 'finding my voice' in Europe. And then you looked at me—with those dead, exhausted eyes—and said: *I am killing myself to keep the roof over your head, and you're dreaming about the weather in Holland.*"

The red digits on his wristwatch flickered: **12:00 AM.**

The circuit broke.

It was not a blur; it was an amputation.

Evan felt the words she had just spoken detach from his ribs. The memory of the paper, the shame of the hospital invoice, the image of her crying over the Rotterdam acceptance letter—they dissolved like sugar poured into boiling water. He understood the grammar of the English sentences she had just uttered, but the emotional crime behind them was gone.

He looked up at her face.

He felt no guilt. He felt no remorse. He felt only the flat, terrifying vacuum of an observer reading a report about two strangers who had failed each other in a city he didn't care about.

Clara watched his eyes. She saw the exact second the light went out behind his pupils.

She stepped back into the guest room, her face completely pale.

"You really did it," she whispered, her voice trembling with an uncanny, horrifying realization. "I thought you were just depressed. I thought you were just tired."

She reached out and gripped the brass knob of the door.

"You're not here anymore. You've been dead for weeks."

The door clicked shut. This time, there was no lock turning. There was no need. The wall was already complete.

Evan sat in the hallway until the clock read 1:30 AM.

He didn't cry. You cannot mourn what you no longer possess.

He picked up the silver Olympus recorder, loaded the fifth micro-cassette, and pressed **PLAY**.

The tape hissed. His past voice emerged from the speaker, sounding rougher, more frayed at the edges, like wire being bent back and forth until the core began to heat.

*"Day 5," his voice said. A hollow cough rattled the small speaker. "The fight is gone now, isn't it? Good. That was the heaviest one. That was the day I realized that my love wasn't a shelter; it was an anchor dragging her to the bottom of the harbor.*

*She was going to stay, you know. Even after what I said, she was going to turn down the fellowship, take a retail framing job, and spend the next ten years watching me slowly turn into a bitter, broken-backed machine. She loved me enough to let herself be ruined by me.*



*I couldn't let her do that.*

*The clinic requires seven sessions because the neuro-pathways have to be peeled back in reverse order of significance. But you need to know something, Evan—something they didn't put in the glossy brochure."*

A long, ragged intake of breath over the microphone. The sound of knuckles cracking.

*"Tape 06 is her face. When you wake up next Sunday, you won't recognize her features. She will look like a stranger on a subway train. If she is still in the apartment when that happens, she will see it in your eyes, and it will break her in a way she can never recover from.*

*Pack your bag, Evan. Don't be there when the sun comes up next week. Leave her the flat, leave her the deposit, take your clothes, and disappear into the crowd.*

*Give her that much dignity. At least let her think you chose to leave."*

The machine clicked off.

Evan didn't move. He dragged his knees up to his chest, rested his forehead against the cold wood of the floorboards, and pulled the black notebook from his jacket pocket with numb fingers.

Under the harsh yellow hallway bulb, he wrote the fifth entry:

**NOVEMBER 1. DAY 5.**

*The fight has been deleted.*

*I don't know why we broke.*

*I don't know what I took from her.*

*She looked at me tonight and told me I was dead.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*She was right.*

*Next week, I lose her face.*

*The tape told me to run.*

*It told me to pack my bag and leave before Sunday so she doesn't have to see a stranger looking back at her.*

*I am not running.*

*If I built this machine to save her, I am going to stay in the room until the engine tears itself apart.*

He closed the book, laid the tape recorder beside the door, and sat guard in the hallway, waiting for the dawn that would take her features away forever.

## CHAPTER 6

### DAY 6 — THE CONTOUR

The week did not pass in hours; it dissolved in seconds, like ice left under boiling water.

Evan did not pack his bag.

He didn't sleep in the bedroom, either. He dragged an old woolen army blanket out of the hall cupboard and took up residence on the sagging sofa in the living room, four feet from the front door. He kept his boots on, laces loosely tied, like a watchman waiting for a fire alarm he knew was wired to go off.

On Wednesday, he tried to draw her.

He pulled a fresh sheet of white sketch paper from Clara's abandoned drafting table, sat beneath the bare bulb of the kitchen, and gripped a dull 2B graphite pencil. He closed his eyes. He tried to summon the curve of her upper lip—the slight, uneven rise on the left side where she had split the skin tumbling off a bicycle at fourteen. He tried to see the dark arc of her eyebrows, the precise brown of her irises that turned almost amber when she stood near a south-facing window.

The pencil hovered over the blank white sheet.

His fingers twitched. He drew an oval. He sketched two generic almond shapes for the eyes, a straight line for the nose, a slash for the mouth.

It was a face. It had two eyes, a forehead, and a chin. But it was not *her*. It was an anatomical diagram. It was an anonymous mannequin pulled from a department store catalogue.

He pressed the pencil down until the lead snapped with a dry *crack*, tearing a jagged hole through the center of the paper.

By Friday evening, Clara had packed two large cardboard cartons.

They sat stacked near the entryway, taped shut with brown parcel tape, labeled in her bold marker: **STUDIO SUPPLIES / PRINTS**. She had not mentioned leaving, and he had not asked. The flat had reached an unspoken armistice where survival meant avoiding any sentence longer than three words.

On Saturday, she did not go to work.

She spent the afternoon cleaning the flat with an aggressive, punishing thoroughness. She scrubbed the stove burners with wire wool until the raw steel gleamed. She wiped the skirting boards, vacuumed the worn wool rug, and stripped the spare bed, leaving the clean sheets folded into a precise square on the mattress.

At ten that night, the apartment smelled of bleach, pine disinfectant, and cold draft.

Evan was sitting on the edge of the sofa, his elbows braced against his knees, his hands clasped tight enough to turn his knuckles white. The Olympus recorder lay on the coffee table beside the sixth micro-cassette:

## 06 – THE CONTOUR

The kitchen faucet dripped once. Twice. A rhythmic, wet metronome.

The bedroom door opened. Clara walked into the living room.

She was dressed in a dark wool sweater, her trench coat draped over the back of the single armchair by the window. Her overnight duffel bag was zipped shut, sitting upright by her boots.

She walked over to the opposite side of the coffee table. She didn't look at the micro-cassette, though her eyes lingered for a fraction of a second on the scuffed silver casing of the Olympus recorder.

"The lease is paid through the end of November," she said, her voice flat, conversational, and drained of blood. "I spoke to the landlord yesterday. He said if you sign the transfer form, you can stay on month-to-month, or find someone to take over your share. My deposit is yours. Don't worry about returning it."

Evan looked up at her.

*11:52 PM.*

Eight minutes.

"You're leaving tonight," he said. It was not a question.

"My train is at twelve-forty," she replied, looking at the dark pane of the window. "A friend from the gallery is picking me up downstairs at midnight. We're driving to the regional depot."

"Clara—"

"Don't," she interrupted, not harshly, but with a terrifying, absolute finality that made the air between them feel like dry sheetrock. "I'm not angry, Evan. That's what you don't understand. I watched you break your own neck for three years trying to keep this flat, keep the heat on, keep me from seeing how bad the ledger was getting. You carried everything in your chest until your ribs caved in, and you never once thought that maybe I

would have rather lived in a cold room with you than watch you slowly die in front of me."

She looked directly down at him.

Her dark eyes caught the dim yellow bulb of the hallway. For an instant, Evan saw the woman who had stood under the rain, the woman who had split her lip at fourteen, the woman who had signed away Rotterdam because she couldn't bear to let him sink alone.

"I loved you enough to let you drag me down," she whispered, her lips trembling slightly before she pulled them into a straight, hard line. "That was my mistake. And your mistake was thinking that if you made yourself numb, it wouldn't hurt to let go."

On his wrist, the digital watch gave a single, almost inaudible chime:

**12:00 AM.**

The sensation did not arrive at his temples this time. It struck behind his eyes.

A sudden, sharp flash of white static—like an old television monitor being kicked in the dark. For two seconds, the room swam in a sickening, vertiginous haze.

Then the static cleared.

Evan blinked. He shook his head, clearing the chemical fog from his throat.

He looked across the glass coffee table.

A woman was standing there.

She was wearing a dark wool sweater. She had shoulder-length brown hair, cut blunt above her collarbones. Her eyes were dark, almost black, set beneath narrow, arching eyebrows. She had a straight nose, pale skin, and hands that showed faint traces of charcoal under the fingernails.

He knew she was an adult human female. He knew she had lived in this apartment. He knew she had packed the two brown cardboard boxes by the door.

He knew, with absolute mathematical certainty, that her name was Clara.

Yet looking at her face was like staring at an incomprehensible foreign script he had never learned to read. There was no familiarity. No spark of recognition in the optic nerve. No emotional contour that tied the shape of her jaw or the curvature of her mouth to a single moment in his existence.

She was a stranger who had walked into his living room with keys to the front door.

He stared at her, his lips parting, his breath freezing in his chest. His eyes scanned her features frantically, searching for the anchor: *The mole below the collarbone?* *The hair clip?* *The line of her chin?*

They were just physical shapes. They were just coordinates on a human skull.

Clara stood motionless beneath his gaze.

She waited three agonizing seconds. She watched his pupils dilate, watched the sheer, unvarnished vacancy swallow the light behind his irises.

She saw that he was looking at her, but not seeing her.

A small, ragged gasp broke from her throat—the first sound of genuine, uncontainable agony she had let out in six weeks. She raised one hand to her mouth, her shoulders caving inward as if an invisible weight had slammed into her sternum.

"God," she choked out behind her fingers. "You don't even know who I am."

"Clara," he began, the word feeling utterly synthetic on his tongue, like a foreign noun he had memorized from a textbook ten minutes prior.

"Don't say it," she cried out, her voice breaking into a ragged sob. She grabbed the handle of her duffel bag, her boots skidding against the floorboards as she stumbled toward the door. "Don't use my name. Don't look at me like that."

She pulled the door open with a violent yank. The cold draft from the concrete stairwell rushed into the flat, smelling of damp leaves and autumn exhaust.

She didn't look back. Her boots slammed down the concrete steps, the sound echoing through the stairwell in rapid, uneven beats until the glass lobby doors downstairs swung shut with a distant, muffled boom.

The flat fell silent.

Evan did not stand up.

He sat on the sagging sofa in the empty room, looking at the door hanging open to the dark landing. A draft pulled at his trouser leg, but his skin was numb.

He reached out. His fingers were stiff, moving like wooden pegs.



He picked up the silver Olympus recorder, ejected tape 05, and snapped 06 – **THE CONTOUR** into place.

He pressed **PLAY**.

The tape hiss filled the room—hollow, dry, and relentless.

His past self spoke. The voice on the recording was barely a whisper now, exhausted, ruined, coming from a man who sounded like he had already buried his own heart in the yard.

*"She's gone, isn't she?"*

The tape hissed. The sound of a pen clicking in the background.

*"If she had any self-respect left, she walked out that door the second she saw your eyes. That was the whole point, Evan. You couldn't tell her to leave. You were too weak, and she was too loyal. So you made yourself into an empty house. Nobody stays in a house without heat.*

*Take the seventh tape out of the drawer. Tomorrow morning, call the clinic. Tell them the protocol is complete. They will give you the final injection on Wednesday to stabilize the neural blockers. After that, the baseline resets.*

*You won't remember the tram stop.*

*You won't remember the song.*

*You won't remember the kiss on the fire escape.*

*You won't remember the ring, the hospital bill, or the look on her face when she realized you couldn't see her.*

*You will just be a man who lives in a flat with four bare walls and a clean slate. You will sleep eight hours a night. You will eat three meals a day.*

*Your chest won't hurt when you check your bank balance, because you won't be carrying two lives on a single pair of lungs.*

*You wanted peace, Evan.*

*Welcome to the silence."*

The mechanical motor gave a dull *whir-click* and stopped.

Evan stared at the recorder.

He picked up the black notebook from the table, opened to the sixth page, and laid the pen across the paper.

His hand hovered.

For the first time in six weeks, he did not write her name. He did not write down a detail about her hair, her eyes, or her laugh. He realized with sickening, icy clarity that if he wrote down what she looked like, it would be a lie—a description of a woman he had never seen before in his life.

Instead, his hand moved across the paper in three ragged lines:

**NOVEMBER 8. DAY 6.**

*I looked at her tonight.*

*I saw nothing.*

*She ran.*

*I built an empty house, and now I am the only one trapped inside it.*

He closed the notebook.

He walked over to the entryway, pushed the front door shut, and turned the heavy deadbolt. Then he picked up the sixth tape, set it beside the

fifth, and looked at the locked desk drawer where the final plastic case sat waiting in the dark:

**07 – THE CLEAN SLATE**

## CHAPTER 7

### DAY 7 — THE CLEAN SLATE

The final cassette did not wait in the drawer.

Evan took it out on Sunday morning and set it on the kitchen table beside an empty glass.

#### 07 — THE CLEAN SLATE

The plastic shell was virgin, unmarred by fingerprints. Beside it lay a folded appointment slip from a facility three suburbs away: *St. Jude Neuro-Cognitive Annex. Wednesday, November 11. Final Stabilization Infusion.*

Without that stabilization, the suppression protocol remained an open surgical incision. The erased pathways were blocked, but the neurochemical seal wasn't permanent; the brain would spend months firing stray synapses into dead ends, generating phantom aches, sleep paralysis, and the suffocating panic of missing something you could no longer name. The final shot was the chemical cauterization. It promised to burn the nerve roots clean down to the bone.

He had three days.

The flat did not belong to him anymore. Without Clara's presence, the rooms shrank into mere drywall and linoleum. Her coats were gone from the peg by the door. The tortoiseshell hair clip was missing from the windowsill. The chipped mint-green mug had been packed into one of the cartons that her gallery friend had hauled down the stairwell at midnight.

All that remained was the smell of pine disinfectant and the black notebook sitting on the glass table.

He spent Monday walking through the logistics warehouse in a state of clinical detachment. He moved pallets, verified shipping manifests, checked customs clearance seals on twenty-foot shipping containers, and signed invoices with a hand that did not shake.

Colleagues passed him with small nods. No one noticed that the man operating the forklift was a hollow husk. The modern world does not demand that you have an interior life; it only requires that your output matches the shift quota.

On Tuesday night, Evan did not pack a suitcase. He did not buy groceries.

He sat at the kitchen table, watched the clock crawl past 11:00 PM, and stared at the seventh tape.

He didn't need to wait for midnight. The seven days were up. The architecture of their history had already been systematically demolished:

- The coordinate where they met was gone.
- The song was static.
- The first kiss was an entry in an encyclopedia.
- The promise on the silver ring was cold metal.
- The argument that broke them was deleted.
- Her face was a blank portrait.

What was left to lose at midnight?

The name.

The final anchor. The last sequence in the protocol wasn't the deletion of an event; it was the deletion of the reference point itself. Once the name vanished, the other missing pieces would cease to be mysteries. A man who forgets where he met someone only hurts if he knows there is a *someone* to remember. Delete the name, and the empty rooms stop echoing.

At 11:58 PM, Evan took the silver Olympus recorder, loaded the seventh tape, and rested his index finger on the black **PLAY** button.

The digital watch clicked: **12:00 AM.**

There was no static. There was no flash behind the eyes.

Instead, there was an almost imperceptible settling of the air in the flat, like a furnace shutting off at the end of winter.

Evan looked down at the cover of the black notebook.

On the front, beneath his jagged handwriting from seven weeks ago, was a title he had inscribed in capital letters:

*THINGS I MUST REMEMBER ABOUT...*

The rest of the sentence was blank.

He looked at the empty space after the word *ABOUT*.

He stared at it for five minutes. His mind reached into the dark, searching for the five-letter noun that had occupied every breath of his waking life for five years.

He found nothing.

The name had not been erased like pencil under rubber; the linguistic category had been snipped clean out of his vocabulary. He knew he had

lived with a woman. He knew she had brown hair cut above her collarbones. He knew she worked with ink and paper.

But if an officer stopped him on the street and demanded to know who had packed the cartons in his hallway, he could only give a blank stare.

The house was empty.

The sentinel had finished his watch, and the city he had guarded no longer existed.

Evan pressed **PLAY**.

The motor spun. The magnetic ribbon hissed through the guide pins.

When his voice spoke, it was not the cold, clinical architect from the second tape, nor the furious sentry from the fourth.

It was the voice of a man sitting in the dark with a loaded gun on the table, speaking in the quiet, ruined cadence of total exhaustion.

*"If you're hearing this, it worked."*

A long, hollow silence followed. The sound of rain tapping against a window pane in a room from four months ago.

*"You don't know who she is anymore. You don't know the name you used to whisper when the night shifts broke your back. You don't know why there's a dent on the passenger side of your mattress."*

*Good.*

*You thought amnesia was an act of cowardice, didn't you? While you were digging through the drawers and listening to my tapes, you thought you were hunting down a villain.*

*You weren't. You were looking at an executioner who was also the condemned.*

*We were killing her, Evan. Not with fists, and not with cruelty. We were killing her with our own small, suffocating reality. We took a woman who painted light, and we turned her into an accountant who spent her evenings checking the meter on the gas cylinder and calculating whether we could afford fresh vegetables.*

*She stayed because she loved us. And that was the poison. Her love was so pure that she would have let herself be ground down into gray dust right beside us in that flat, just so we wouldn't have to die alone in the cold.*

*You didn't erase her to save yourself from the pain.*

*You erased her because it was the only way to make her leave.*

*A woman like that will never abandon a man who is bleeding in front of her. She will stay until the infection takes her too. The only way to set her free was to turn yourself into stone—to become a monster so cold, so hollow, so absent that staying with you became more terrifying than stepping out into the dark.*

*Tomorrow is Wednesday. Go to the St. Jude Annex. Take the shot. Burn the roots.*

*Do not look for her in the city. Do not look for her at the tram stops. Do not look for her in the galleries.*

*Let her fly, Evan. And you... you finally get to rest."*

A harsh mechanical click severed the tape. The silver Olympus clicked into neutral, the gears settling into a dead, permanent stop.

Evan sat motionless in the dim yellow light of the kitchen.



A single tear rolled down his right cheek, cold and unprompted, falling onto the glass table with a quiet *tap*.

He did not wipe it away.

He didn't know who he was crying for. He had no face to attach to the grief, no name to anchor the sob that rose in his throat like bile. He was mourning a phantom—an invisible weight that had been lifted from his ribs, leaving behind a cavity so wide and cold that the draft from the hallway whistled right through his marrow.

He picked up his pen.

He opened the black notebook to the final page.

His hand was completely still. No tremors. No anger. Just the clean, terminal precision of an engineer signing off on a completed demolition.

He wrote the final entry:

**NOVEMBER 11. DAY 7.**

*The name is gone.*

*The debt is paid.*

*The flat is cold, but the roof did not fall.*

*I understand now.*

*The mistake wasn't loving her.*

*The mistake was believing that a man could keep someone warm by burning down the house around them.*

*Tomorrow, I take the final shot.*

*I will not look for her.*

*I will let the tide recede.*

He closed the notebook, took the silver band from the key ring, and slipped it into the dark slot of the Olympus recorder where the tape had been.

He shut the plastic drawer, left the keys on the center of the kitchen table, and walked out of the apartment, locking the deadbolt behind him with a single, irreversible turn.

## CHAPTER 8

### THE SOMATIC ARCHIVE

The St. Jude Neuro-Cognitive Annex was not a hospital. It was located on the third floor of a nondescript corporate park in the light-industrial belt, nestled between an architectural drafting firm and an import-export broker.

There were no red crosses, no sirens, no stretchers. Only smoked-glass doors, brushed aluminum signage, and the low, continuous whisper of an industrial HVAC unit filtering conditioned air through acoustic ceiling tiles.

Evan sat on an olive-green vinyl armchair in the corner of the waiting room, holding his intake slip between thumb and forefinger.

The room held four other people. A middle-aged man in a tailored charcoal suit reading a financial weekly without turning the page. A young woman with red-rimmed eyes staring unblinkingly at the water dispenser. None of them looked at each other. They sat with the stiff, rigid posture of people sitting outside an interview where the position had already been eliminated.

This was the quiet trade of modern mercy: you did not come here to heal; you came here to excise.

"Mr. Vance?"

The voice belonged to a woman in pale blue clinical scrubs standing in the hallway aperture. She carried a tablet computer encased in thick rubberized plastic.

Evan stood up. His knees gave a faint, stiff click. He followed her down a linoleum corridor illuminated by cold, flickerless LEDs. The doors on either side were solid oak, bearing numbers instead of names: *Suite 301*, *Suite 302*, *Suite 303*.

Suite 304 contained no examination table, no stainless-steel instruments. It held two high-backed leather armchairs, a low walnut coffee table, and an articulated monitor arm mounted to the wall.

A man in his early fifties sat in the armchair opposite the window. He wore a crisp white shirt with no tie, graying hair cropped short, and rimless glasses that caught the pale autumn daylight.

"Evan. Please, sit," Dr. Miller said, indicating the vacant leather chair. His voice was practiced, measured to project the exact midpoint between clinical neutrality and bureaucratic reassurance. "How was the commute from the eastern borough?"

"Clear," Evan said, his voice grating in his own throat like dry gravel. He sat down. The leather was cold against his wool trousers.

Dr. Miller tapped the glass face of his tablet. "According to the transponder log on your home dispenser, the seventh suppression compound was delivered on schedule Sunday at midnight. That marks the completion of Phase One."

"Phase One."

"The targeted synaptic decoupling," Miller explained, turning the tablet slightly so Evan could see the graphic representation of a human brain

rendered in cool greens and blues. Across the temporal lobes, seven discrete clusters were highlighted in dull gray, like areas of an aerial map where the power grid had been methodically knocked offline. "The contextual anchors—spatial, auditory, tactile, covenantal, conflict, facial, and nominal—have been decoupled from the primary retrieval pathways. As far as your conscious cortex is concerned, the subject does not exist."

Evan stared at the gray patches on the screen.

*The subject.*

"Is it done, then?" Evan asked.

"Not quite," Miller said, setting the tablet on the walnut table. He leaned back, tenting his fingers over his stomach. "The brain is an aggressive organ, Evan. It despises an empty shelf. When it detects a localized suppression zone of this magnitude, the autonomic nervous system attempts to bridge the gap. It fires exploratory impulses into the necrotic pathways. Without stabilization, you will experience severe somatic drift."

"Somatic drift?"

"The mind forgets," Miller said calmly. "The body does not. The nervous system stores trauma, habit, and intimacy in muscle tension, galvanic skin response, and resting pulse rates. You will wake up at three in the morning reaching for a body that isn't there. You will smell burnt toast or rain on concrete and experience panic attacks without an identifiable trigger. You will suffer from the phantom limb of a person you cannot name."

The doctor reached into a brushed-steel cabinet beneath the window and withdrew a small, heavy black case. He popped the latches.

Inside rested a single pneumatic injector—a sleek cylinder of brushed titanium with a narrow glass reservoir containing three milliliters of a clear, viscous lipid compound.

"This is the lipid antagonist," Miller said, lifting the cylinder. The liquid inside shifted slowly, heavy as mineral oil. "It binds irreversibly to the neuro-receptors in those seven target clusters. It doesn't just block retrieval; it chemically cauterizes the pathways. In forty-eight hours, the synaptic gaps collapse permanently. No drift. No phantom aches. The slate becomes truly clean."

Miller set the injector beside the tablet.

"Before I administer the stabilizer, clinical protocol requires a final baseline stress-verification test. We need to confirm that semantic recognition is completely flat."

Miller picked up an unlabelled manila folder from the desk. He opened it, drew out a single 4×6 glossy photograph, and laid it face-up on the walnut table between them.

Evan looked down.

It was Clara.

The photograph had clearly been taken years ago, long before the cold silence had settled into their flat. She was sitting on the wooden steps of a rented seaside cabin, wearing an oversized knit sweater, squinting into a low afternoon sun with salt wind whipping strands of dark hair across her cheek. She was laughing—a wide, uncalculated laugh that showed the slight overlap of her front teeth.

Evan stared at the image.

He searched the catalog of his mind. He waited for the tram rails. He waited for the indie record. He waited for the fire escape on 8th Street. He waited for the silver ring, the hospital invoice, her voice in the hallway.

Nothing moved. The image was an artifact from a stranger's estate sale. He could recognize the lighting, the grain of the print, the composition of the frame. But the woman was nobody. She had no name. She had no place in his lineage.

*It worked*, he thought. *The machine held.*

Then, without warning, his sternum seized.

His heart hammered once against his ribs—a violent, concussive jolt that sent a surge of adrenaline tearing through his arteries. His lungs locked in mid-breath. His palms went slick with cold sweat, and a sharp, metallic taste rose in the back of his mouth like copper pennies dissolving on his tongue.

His vision tunnelled until the room blurred into gray static, leaving only the photograph on the table.

He didn't know who she was.

He didn't know why she was laughing.

Yet his physical body—the bone, the blood, the meat—was screaming with a grief so immense, so suffocating, that he had to grip the arms of the leather chair to keep from vomiting onto the carpet.

A rhythmic, urgent chime sounded from the tablet on the table.

Dr. Miller looked at the monitor arm, where the biometric sensor in Evan's armchair was feeding live telemetry to the screen:

**HEART RATE: 138 BPM**

**GALVANIC SKIN RESPONSE: CRITICAL ELEVATION**

**CORTISOL SPIKE: +210%**

Miller didn't blink. He reached out and slid the photograph back into the manila folder, turning the paper over so the white backing faced the ceiling.

Within five seconds, the violent tremor in Evan's hands began to subside. His lungs opened. The metallic taste receded, leaving only an ache behind his ribs that felt like broken glass settling into soft tissue.

"Fascinating," Miller murmured, jotting a notation on his screen. "Severe somatic resonance. The cognitive erasure is one hundred percent effective—you didn't register her name or identity—but the sub-cortical conditioning is still firing on all cylinders. Your amygdala recognizes the absence as a fatal wound."

Miller picked up the titanium injector. He checked the seal on the glass reservoir with a flick of his index finger.

"This is precisely why Phase Two is mandatory," Miller said, standing up and stepping toward Evan's chair. "Without this shot, you will live the rest of your life in an ambient state of panic. You will be a haunted house with no ghost to blame."

He pointed the sterile nozzle toward Evan's neck, three inches below the jawline where the carotid artery pulsed against the skin.

"Tilt your head slightly to the left, Evan. It's a three-second delivery. A slight pressure, then cold. By Friday, the phantom will be dead."

Evan looked at the metal tip of the injector.



He felt the hollow ache in his chest—the raw, ragged cavity left behind by five years of devotion he had paid eighty thousand dollars to destroy. It hurt. It felt like dying in slow motion under cold fluorescent lighting.

*The mind forgets. The body does not.*

If he let the cold lipid enter his bloodstream, the ache would stop. His heart rate would settle into a flat, steady seventy beats a minute. He would leave this corporate park, drive back to his apartment, sign the single-occupancy lease, and live his life like a man who had never held anything heavier than a shopping bag.

He would be free.

And she would be gone—not just from his thoughts, but from the universe. The only human being who had borne witness to the fact that they had once stood against the world together would be a woman in an unfamiliar city, carrying the entire weight of their ruined history by herself.

"Evan?" Miller asked, the metal tip hovering two inches from his skin. "Head to the left, please."

Evan looked at the doctor's eyes. They were gray, perfectly calm, entirely devoid of malice. The eyes of a technician operating an incinerator.

"No," Evan said.

Miller lowered the injector by half an inch, his brow furrowing slightly in administrative confusion. "Excuse me?"

"Put it down," Evan said.

His voice was quiet, but the tremor was gone.

"Mr. Vance, we discussed this during your intake evaluation four months ago," Miller said, his tone shifting into the patronizing cadence of a teacher

addressing a recalcitrant child. "You signed the waiver. If you leave this clinic without stabilization, the neural blockades will begin to degrade unevenly over the next three to six months. You will suffer from cognitive dissonance, severe depression, and unresolvable emotional leakage. You cannot reverse the procedure, but you will not be whole."

"I know," Evan said.

He stood up from the armchair. He did not look at the manila folder on the table. He did not need to see the photograph again.

"I wanted an easy way out," Evan murmured, looking through the smoked-glass window at the gray highway running between the concrete warehouses below. "I thought if I couldn't feel the fire, it meant the house wasn't burning. But you don't get to erase the cost just because you're too weak to carry the invoice."

"Mr. Vance, this is medically ill-advised—"

"I don't care," Evan said.

He turned toward the door.

"You will be back in six weeks," Miller called after him, his voice clinical, flat, entirely certain of the algorithmic inevitability of human frailty. "When the sleeplessness starts, when the panic attacks peak, you will be back in that chair."

Evan paused with his hand on the brushed-aluminum lever of the door.

He felt the hollow space behind his ribs. He felt the cold air of the hallway on his face. He felt the terrible, unbearable weight of being a man who had forgotten the face of the woman he loved, but who still had to live with the scar of her absence.

"Maybe," Evan said softly. "But until then, I'm going to let it hurt."

He pushed the door open and walked out into the corridor, leaving the titanium injector sitting unused on the walnut table.

## CHAPTER 9

### THE PHANTOM INVENTORY

The highway back from the industrial belt was choked with gray exhaust and cold, steady drizzle.

Evan did not take the commuter bus. He walked.

He walked six miles along the cracked concrete shoulder of the access road, his hands buried deep inside his windbreaker pockets, letting the spray of passing articulated lorries mist against his jaw.

His body was in open rebellion. Every half-mile, his diaphragm would seize in a dry, violent spasm—a ghost of a sob with no thought attached to it. His pulse remained elevated, fluttering against the hollow of his throat like a trapped moth.

*Somatic drift.*

Dr. Miller had called it a defect, an administrative inconvenience to be cauterized with three milliliters of synthetic lipid. But as Evan walked beneath the rusting overpasses, feeling the damp seep through his wool socks, the pain felt like the only clean thing he had left. It was proof that he wasn't a machine. The ledger in his brain had been wiped, but his marrow still held the stain.

When he reached the apartment building, the lobby was warm and smelled of boiled cabbage from the ground-floor superintendent's flat.

He climbed the concrete steps slowly, his boots dragging. On the fourth-floor landing, he stopped outside door 4B.

He pulled out his keys.

For the first time in five years, there was no sound on the other side of the timber. No radio murmuring in the kitchen. No kettle clinking against the cast-iron stove. No muffled footsteps crossing the floorboards.

Just the vacuum.

He unlocked the deadbolt, pushed the door open, and stepped inside.

The apartment was freezing. The radiator valves were cold iron. Clara had shut off the heating before she left, a small, ingrained habit of an artist who knew the precise cost of a kilowatt-hour.

Evan did not turn the boiler on. He took off his soaked jacket, hung it on the brass peg, and walked through the four rooms with the slow, methodical scrutiny of an insurance claims adjuster surveying a fire.

Now that the protocol was complete and the seven tapes had played out, he was no longer waiting for midnight. The execution was over. What remained was the salvage operation.

He walked into the kitchen.

The counters were bare. The chipped mint-green mug was gone. But on the magnetic knife strip above the sink, there was an empty gap between the chef's knife and the bread knife—the paring knife she had used to slice apples on Sunday mornings was missing.

He walked into the bathroom.

Her toothbrush was gone from the ceramic cup. But on the edge of the medicine cabinet mirror, someone had used a grease pencil to mark a small line at eye level, six inches below his own. A reference mark.

He went to the small guest alcove where she had slept for the last two weeks.

The folding cot was stripped bare to the striped mattress ticking. The floorboards were swept clean, the dust swept into a neat pile by the baseboard and abandoned.

Then he saw the desk.

It was an old architectural drafting table with a tilt-top surface, scarred with decades of gouges and dark splatters of India ink. She had taken her heavy portfolio cases and her expensive French papers. But leaning against the radiator in the corner was a flat package wrapped in brown butcher paper, tied with three tight loops of rough hemp twine.

Taped to the front was an unsealed envelope.

Evan's fingers went cold.

He stepped across the bare floorboards, picked up the envelope, and slid out the single index card inside.

The handwriting was not his neat, technical block print. It was a fluid, unhurried cursive, written with a flexible steel nib and waterproof black ink:

*Evan,*

*I know you found the tapes. I saw the wood splintered on the bureau drawer two weeks ago.*

*I know what you did to your head.*

*You think you're so clever, hiding behind schedules and invoices. You think you invented sacrifice. You always believed that if you took all the cold onto your own back, nobody else would freeze.*

*You idiot.*

*You can take your tram stops. You can take your records and your fire escapes and your silver rings. If you need to make yourself blind so you don't have to watch me pack, then take it. I won't beg a ghost to remember.*

*But you don't get to erase what I made while you were building your walls.*

*This was supposed to be for our fifth anniversary next month. It's not a memory. You don't need a neuron to look at ink on paper. It's just work. Keep it, or burn it with the rest of your files.*

*Goodbye, sentry.*

Evan stared at the card.

The signature at the bottom was a single, sweeping initial: **C**.

He read the card three times. The words registered in his linguistic processing centers, but the emotional memory of her voice reading them was entirely absent. He could not hear the timbre of her throat. He could not see her mouth forming the word *idiot*.

The letters sat on the white cardboard like an ancient inscription excavated from an arid tomb.

He set the card on the drafting table. With numb fingers, he snapped the hemp twine around the butcher paper.

He peeled the brown paper back, folding it into crisp, deliberate creases, until the object inside lay exposed to the gray afternoon light.

It was an unframed woodcut print, approximately sixteen by twenty inches, pulled on heavy, cream-colored Japanese mulberry paper.

The image was stark black and bone white.

It depicted an intersection of the city during a blinding torrential storm. The perspective was low, looking up from the gutter toward a rusted iron tram shelter. Streetlights cast long, shivering white flares across black asphalt pooled with rainwater.

Beneath the shelter stood two human figures.

One was a woman, slight, her shoulders drawn inward against the damp, her features deliberately obscured by the cross-hatched rain slanting across the frame.

The other was a man.

He was standing half-in, half-out of the awning's shelter, holding an umbrella with two fractured, bent ribs that pointed uselessly toward the gray sky. He wasn't looking at the street. He wasn't looking for the tram.

He had his head turned sideways, looking down at the woman, his face carved with such microscopic, devastating accuracy that Evan felt his knees buckle against the baseboard.

The woodcut captured every line of his forehead. The tight, defensive clench of his jaw. The slight hollow beneath his cheekbone from skipped meals. The exhaustion of an eldest son who had spent his youth running through the dark to catch trains he couldn't afford.

And in his eyes—rendered with dozens of tiny, razor-sharp gouges of a steel blade into hard pearwood—was a look of such terrifying, unguarded terror that it knocked the breath clean out of Evan's lungs.

It was not a portrait of a lover.

It was a forensic record of a man who had already decided, on the very night they met, that he would rather drown than let a single drop of water touch her sleeve.



At the bottom of the print, in the lower right-hand margin, was the edition number and the title, written in faint graphite pencil:

*1/1. The First Night.*

Evan sank onto the bare wood of the floor, his back resting against the cast-iron ribs of the cold radiator.

He held the cream-colored sheet by its deckled edges, his thumbs hovering a millimeter above the dried black ink, terrified that the grease of his skin might smudge the lines.

*The First Meeting.*

*Day 1.*

The memory was gone. Dr. Miller's chemicals had burned the synaptic bridge to ashes. He would never recall the sound of the rain against the rusted iron. He would never smell the wet dog fur. He would never remember the joke he made to the stranger on the platform.

The past was dead.

Yet sitting in the freezing alcove, staring at the print, Evan felt a single, clean tear break from his lash and roll down into the stubble on his chin.

His mind could not remember her.

But holding the paper in his hands, he knew, with a certainty deeper than neurology, that he had loved her with every broken bone in his body.

He reached into his breast pocket, drew out the black hardback notebook, and laid it open across his lap.

He flipped past Day 1, past the song, past the kiss, past the ring, past the fight, past her face, past the clean slate of Day 7.

He turned to a fresh, unlined page.

He uncapped his pen, pressed the nib against the paper, and wrote:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 01.**

*I did not take the stabilizer.*

*Dr. Miller says the phantom will haunt the house.*

*Let it.*

*She left a woodcut behind.*

*It is titled 'The First Night.'*

*In the print, my umbrella has two broken ribs.*

*I look terrified.*

*I don't know her name.*

*I don't know where she went.*

*The clinic took the coordinates, but she left the map pinned to the wall.*

*I am not going to chase her.*

*A man who burns his own house down does not get to ask for the ashes back.*

*But I am going to buy a frame for this paper.*

*And I am going to hang it by the door.*

*So that every time I leave this flat, I remember what it looks like when a man forgets how to live.*

## CHAPTER 10

### SOMATIC DRIFT

The body is a creature of rote discipline. It does not read medical waivers, and it does not recognize the authority of clinical neuro-blockers.

Evan discovered this at 3:14 on a Tuesday morning.

He woke with his left arm flung across the empty mattress, his palm open, his fingers curled slightly as if cradling the hollow between someone's shoulder blades.

The sheet beneath his hand was ice-cold.

The moment his skin registered the vacancy, his autonomic system detonated. Adrenaline ripped through his veins like battery acid. His chest heaved, pulling in thin, dry air in short, jagged gasps, his heart hammering against his sternum with such violence that his vision pulsed in rhythm with his pulse.

He kicked the duvet off, tumbled off the mattress, and hit the cold floorboards on his hands and knees.

*Breathe.*

He pressed his forehead to the wood, counting backward from one hundred.

*Ninety-nine. Ninety-eight. Ninety-seven.*

There was no fire. The locks on the front door were turned. The stove burners were cold. There was no rational, cognitive reason for his nervous system to believe he was in fatal danger.

Yet his ribs felt as though they were being crushed by hydraulic clamps. A cold sweat soaked through the collar of his t-shirt, sticking the gray cotton to his spine.

This was the somatic drift Dr. Miller had promised: the ghost in the machine. His conscious mind had been scrubbed of the woman's name, her voice, and her face, but his spinal cord still remembered the exact displacement of air she produced when she slept beside him. His motor neurons still anticipated thirty-eight kilograms of warmth on the left side of the bed.

When the warmth failed to materialize, his brain interpreted the void as an ambush.

He stayed on the floor for twenty minutes until the chemical wash began to drain from his bloodstream, leaving him hollow, shivering, and nauseated.

By Thursday, the muscle memory had become an open torment.

Habit had carved deep ruts into his behavior over five years, and without the memories to explain them, the rituals felt like the compulsive tics of a madman.

At six in the evening, standing in the narrow galley kitchen after a twelve-hour shift, he found himself measuring two mugs of tap water into the kettle. He set out two ceramic mugs on the laminate counter—his plain white one, and the empty space where the mint-green mug used to sit. He reached into the cupboard for the tea caddy, pinched three dried leaves, and then reached for the sugar jar.

He scooped half a teaspoon of white sugar and tipped it into the empty air above the second, nonexistent mug.

The grains fell onto the countertop, scattering across the laminate like crushed glass.

Evan froze, the stainless-steel spoon still pinched between his fingers.

He stared at the spilled sugar.

He did not take sugar. He had drunk his tea black and bitter since he was sixteen.

*Why did I do that?*

His brain produced no answer. It was a reflex without a premise—a severed tendon twitching in dead muscle.

He set the spoon down with a clatter. Slowly, with the precision of an archaeologist clearing a trench, he swept the sugar into his palm and dropped it into the stainless-steel sink, turning the cold tap until the white crystals melted down the brass drain.

On Friday, he bought the frame.

He took the tram two stops past the freight depot to an old framing workshop run by an elderly Greek man who worked in the basement of a brick tenement. The air inside smelled of bone glue, sawdust, and linseed oil.

Evan did not ask for decorative moldings or museum-grade anti-reflective glass.

"Plain black oak," Evan said, his voice flat. "Matted on white rag."

The framer laid Clara's woodcut on a sheet of clean felt, inspecting the corners with calloused, ink-stained thumbs.

"Good work," the old man murmured, squinting through heavy bifocals at the slanting lines of rain, the fractured umbrella ribs, and the haunted, desperate look in the man's carved eyes. "Real hand-pulled relief. You don't see linework like this much anymore. Everyone uses digital plotters now. Who made it?"

Evan looked at the signature in the lower right-hand corner: the single, elegant pencil letter *C*.

"A stranger," Evan said.

The old man glanced up over the rims of his glasses, held Evan's gaze for two seconds, and did not press further. He knew the look of a man carrying dead weight.

"Come back in an hour," the framer said.

When Evan returned to the flat, he took a hammer and a single brass nail from his toolbox.

He walked to the entryway. Beside the door, directly opposite the coat rack where he hung his windbreaker every evening, he hammered the brass nail into the plaster.

He hung the frame.

He stepped back three paces.

The print looked back at him. In the dim, overcast daylight filtering through the hallway transom, the image was brutal. The man in the rain—his past self—stood with his feet half-submerged in the gutter, holding a ruined umbrella, his jaw locked in a posture of impossible defense.

*The First Night.*

He stared into his own carved eyes.

"You fool," Evan whispered to the glass. "You thought you could survive becoming nothing."

That night, the drift evolved from physical panic into auditory hallucinations.

He sat on the living room sofa, the black notebook resting closed on his thighs. The apartment building had settled into its midnight hum—the groan of water pipes in the walls, the muffled rumble of traffic on the distant bypass, the intermittent hum of the refrigerator cycling on and off.

Then, from the kitchen, came the sound.

A dull, rhythmic tapping.

*Click. Click. Click.*

It sounded like the blunt end of a tortoiseshell hair clip being tapped against the edge of a ceramic mug while someone waited for a kettle to boil.

Evan's head snapped toward the empty kitchen archway.

The room was pitch-black.

*Click. Click.*

He stood up, his spine rigid. He took three silent steps toward the opening, his heart creeping into his throat.

"Who's there?" he demanded, though he knew the flat was empty.

The clicking stopped.

There was only the refrigerator.

He stood in the dark kitchen, the hair on the back of his neck standing on end, smelling the faint, phantom trace of cedarwood and bitter almonds—scents that had no business existing in an apartment that had been scrubbed with industrial pine disinfectant six days ago.

Dr. Miller had warned him. *The brain despises an empty shelf.* Without the chemical stabilizer, the suppressed pathways were beginning to warp, sending distorted signals ricocheting across his sensory cortex. If he did not return to the clinic, the ghosts would not just inhabit his past; they would colonize his present.

Evan did not turn on the light.

He walked back to the living room in the dark, sat on the sofa, and opened the black notebook by the amber glow of the streetlamp outside the window.

He turned past the seven chapters of his erasure.

He found the page beneath his last entry, uncapped his ballpoint pen, and pressed down hard:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 02.**

*The flat is full of static.*

*My hands keep making tea for two people.*

*I wake up at three in the morning suffocating because my skin cannot find her.*

*I framed the print.*

*It hangs by the door.*



*The man in the ink looks like he was waiting for a bullet.*

*Dr. Miller said this would happen.*

*He said my amygdala would treat her absence like an open artery.*

*He wants me to come back and let him seal the cut.*

*I won't go.*

*If this panic is the only thing left of whatever we built in these rooms,  
then I will let it rattle my bones until they break.*

*I don't have her face.*

*I don't have her name.*

*But I will not let them steal the ache.*

He closed the book, laid it on the cushion beside him, and leaned his head back against the wall, listening to the pipes groan in the cold plaster until the gray dawn broke over the city.

## CHAPTER 11

### THE LEDGER OF PRIDE

A man who makes a religion out of sacrifice will always end up keeping score.

Evan found the box on a Saturday morning beneath a pile of winter blankets in the bottom of the hall wardrobe. It was a heavy cardboard archive carton, the kind used by legal firms for long-term storage, sealed with gray duct tape that had yellowed and peeled along the edges. Written across the lid in his own black permanent marker was a single word: **RECORDS.**

He hauled it into the center of the living room, sat on the bare floorboards with his legs crossed, and cut the tape with a utility blade.

Inside were four years of physical documentation. He had kept everything: water bills, lease renewals, mechanic invoices, paystips from the freight terminal, bank statements stamped with red *PAID* notices, and tax filings dating back to their second year together.

To an outsider, it was the mundane debris of a lower-middle-class household navigating a sluggish economy.

To Evan, reading it without the protective anesthesia of his own memories, it was the crime scene of a marriage.

He opened the oldest folder: **YEAR TWO.**

In the beginning, the ledger was shared. He found receipts for cheap wine, second-hand furniture bought off classified boards, train tickets to the

coast. Tucked between the lease agreements were two small deposit slips into a joint savings account—one in his precise hand, one in her loose, fluid script. Two people pushing thirty-dollar deposits into a shared pool, building a fragile moat against the world.

Then he reached **YEAR THREE**.

The tone of the paper changed. His independent logistics brokerage had collapsed beneath bad client debt and surging fuel costs. The joint account had been drained to pay off three commercial creditors.

In their fourth month of that year, Evan's independent deposits stopped. In their place began a frantic, terrifying flurry of overtime payslips from the sea freight terminal—fifty hours a week, then sixty, then seventy-two. Shift differentials: +15% for graveyard, +25% for weekend standby.

He had become an engine running on redline.

And right alongside his payslips were the gallery receipts.

Evan picked up a sheaf of pale pink duplicate invoices from a small contemporary gallery downtown. They were consignment slips bearing Clara's signature:

- *Relief print on linen, ed. 5/10 — \$180*
- *Monotype on handmade rag — \$220*
- *Set of four small woodcuts, framed — \$350*

Attached to each receipt was a personal check written to Evan, endorsed on the back in Clara's handwriting: *For the heating bill. For the car insurance. For the groceries.*

None of the checks had been cashed.

Evan sat motionless on the floor, holding four uncashed checks from three years ago, the blue ink still legible on the faded paper.

He dug deeper into the folder. He found two more. Then three more from Year Four. Over two thousand dollars in total—small sums earned from late nights carving pearwood under a single desk lamp, offered up with both hands to help him keep the house afloat.

And on the back of the folder, in his own handwriting, was a cold, pencil-written summary of their monthly expenses. Below the total, he had written:

*Self-reliant. Keep her focus on the art. Don't let her carry the flat.*

He closed his eyes. The room tilted.

*Don't let her carry the flat.*

It sounded noble on paper. It sounded like the chivalry of a traditional man who took pride in shielding his partner from the humiliating machinery of survival.

In reality, it was an act of brutal, suffocating arrogance.

By refusing her money, he hadn't protected her; he had disarmed her. He had taken away her right to be an equal stakeholder in their survival. Every uncashed check was a door he had slammed in her face, an unspoken declaration that her contributions were too insignificant to matter, while his suffering was the only real currency in the room.

He had turned his exhaustion into a monopoly.

He reached the folder for **YEAR FIVE**.

The Rotterdam documents were sitting at the top.

The initial acceptance packet was four pages long, printed on crisp European bond paper. Evan read through the terms with a heavy, hollow ache building behind his collarbones: a twelve-month residency at the Visual Arts Institute, a dedicated studio space, an exhibition budget, and a monthly stipend of twelve hundred euros.

Attached to the back was a spreadsheet Clara had drafted in her own hand.

She had worked out the conversion rates. She had calculated the living costs in Rotterdam down to the price of a bicycle and a tram pass. She had left nearly half the stipend untouched, marked in pencil with a small arrow pointing to a separate line:

*To wire back to Evan for the lease.*

She hadn't planned to abandon him.

She had built a bridge. She had created a mathematical equation where both of them could survive—where she could step into the light without letting him drown. She had come to him with a solution forged from her own talent, offering him relief with both hands.

And what had he done?

Evan remembered the words Clara had thrown at him from the guest room doorway on Day 5:

*'I am killing myself to keep the roof over your head, and you're dreaming about the weather in Holland.'*

He hadn't rejected the plan because it was impossible.

He had rejected it because his fragile, terrified ego could not bear the thought of being saved by her. If she paid the rent, if she earned the money

that kept the lights on, then what was he? If he wasn't the martyr holding up the burning ceiling with his bare hands, what use was he to anyone?

He had chosen the misery of his shift work over the salvation she offered, because in his warped, broken mind, suffering was the only proof that he was worth loving.

He dropped the papers onto the floor.

They scattered across the dust, covering the worn planks with white rectangles of bureaucratic failure.

The apartment was dead silent. Outside, the midday traffic droned along the bypass, indifferent to the quiet devastation unfolding on the fourth floor of 4B.

Evan looked up at the wall by the entryway.

There hung the frame.

*The First Night.*

The man in the ink stood under the slanting rain, holding his broken umbrella, with that look of pure, unadulterated terror in his eyes.

Evan looked at the carving with a cold, unforgiving clarity.

He had always thought that terror was born from the fear of failing her.

Now he knew the truth: he was terrified of needing her. He had spent five years running an emotional dictatorship, demanding that she love him, but forbidding her from ever carrying the weight beside him. He had starved her of partnership, starved her of equality, and then had the gall to pay a doctor to erase her because he couldn't stand the sight of the wreckage he had made.

He dragged the black notebook toward him across the floorboards.

He opened to the next clean page, past the entry about Dr. Miller, past the phantom sugar in the kitchen.

He uncapped his pen. He pressed down until the steel tip gouged the fiber of the page:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 03.**

*I went through the boxes today.*

*I found six uncashed checks.*

*She tried to pay the heating.*

*She tried to pay the insurance.*

*I hid them in an envelope and worked sixty-hour weeks instead.*

*I thought I was a martyr.*

*I was just a coward who weaponized his own exhaustion.*

*She didn't want a sentry.*

*She wanted a partner.*

*She offered me her hand in the storm, and I slapped it away because my pride couldn't afford to let her help carry the oar.*

*Rotterdam wasn't her leaving me.*

*It was her trying to pull us both out of the mud.*

*I crushed it under the heel of my boot and told her it was her fault.*

*I don't need a medical scanner to tell me what I am.*

*The erasure wasn't a mercy for her.*

*It was the last, desperate act of a proud man running away from his own reflection.*

He set the pen down.

He didn't close the notebook. He left it lying open among the uncashed checks and the yellowing tax forms, picked up Clara's Rotterdam spreadsheet, and folded it carefully into his breast pocket, right against his ribs, like a debt he finally intended to pay.



## CHAPTER 12

### THE FRAYING EDGE

Dr. Miller had been wrong about one thing.

The neural blockers did not simply dissolve into a clean, permanent blankness. When you refuse to cauterize an open synaptic wound, the brain does not surrender gracefully. It starves, it claws at the dark, and eventually, the wires begin to touch where they were never meant to cross.

It started on Tuesday at the freight depot.

Evan was standing on the wet tarmac of the container yard under a sleet-heavy sky, cross-referencing container serial numbers against a laminated customs manifest. Around him, the diesel engines of sixty-ton gantry cranes roared, exhaust plumes flattening against the damp concrete.

He looked down at line forty-two on his clipboard: *Container 4048-B / Machine Parts / Origin: Rotterdam.*

The word *Rotterdam* struck his optic nerve like a match dropped into dry straw.

Instantly, the acoustic roar of the container yard vanished. The sound of sixty-ton cranes was snuffed out, replaced by the deafening, microscopic sound of pearwood curling beneath a steel gouge—a wet, splintering *shhhk* that vibrated directly against his eardrums.

The air no longer smelled of sulfur and diesel. It smelled of linseed oil, drying gum arabic, and cold rain blowing through a fourth-floor window.

Evan staggered back against the steel flank of a rusted container.

His eyes were wide open, looking at the gray asphalt, but his visual cortex was firing blind. Superimposed over the cranes was the image of an arm—pale, speckled with dark ink to the elbow, a thin silver tendon flexing as fingers gripped a brayer to roll black ink across a wooden block.

*C.*

The vision had no face, no voice, no sequence. It was a single, raw frame torn from a film reel and burned onto his retinas.

"Vance! Look out!"

A hand gripped his collar and yanked him backward with brutal force.

Evan slammed against the wet tarmac just as the iron bumper of a flatbed tractor swept through the space where he had been standing two seconds prior. The air horn blasted—a raw, concussive shriek that shattered the hallucination into jagged white specks.

The yard supervisor stood over him, rain dripping from the brim of his yellow hardhat, his face red with fury.

"Are you out of your mind?" the supervisor shouted over the rain. "You walked right into the traffic lane! What the hell were you staring at?"

Evan sat in the puddle, grease-water soaking through his canvas trousers, his breath ragged in his throat.

He looked down at the clipboard in his lap.

He hadn't checked line forty-two. Instead, with his black grease marker, he had carved five deep, gouging lines across the margin—an exact sketch of the five fingers he had just seen holding the ink roller.

"I slipped," Evan whispered, his voice shaking.

"Pack your kit," the supervisor snapped, spitting onto the tarmac. "Go home. If you show up looking like a zombie tomorrow, don't bother swiping your card."

The city was not safe anymore.

When he took the commuter train back toward the center, the uneven degradation began in earnest. Dr. Miller had called it *cognitive leakage*—the suppressed temporal clusters bleeding erratically into his everyday consciousness without context or anchor.

A girl sitting three seats down tore open an envelope, and Evan felt a sharp, phantom pain in his left thumb, remembering a cut from an X-Acto knife that had healed three years ago.

The train passed over an iron bridge, the wheels clattering with a rhythmic *da-dum, da-dum*, and a voice whispered in the cavity of his skull: "*We're thirty seconds behind the schedule, sentry.*"

He gripped his knees, digging his nails through the denim until his skin bruised.

He couldn't tell what was memory and what was a symptom of a collapsing nervous system. His mind was manufacturing ghosts out of ambient noise, trying desperately to rebuild the woman it was missing using scraps of trash, street signs, and engine hums.

At the central interchange, he saw her.

She was standing forty feet ahead on the crowded platform, waiting near the stairs.

She wore a charcoal coat that hit below the knee, her dark hair cut blunt above her collar, carrying a long cardboard drafting tube beneath her arm. She was shifting her weight from foot to foot against the draft, exactly the way Clara had shifted while waiting for the kettle to boil.

Evan's heart slammed against his ribs like a caged animal.

He didn't think about Dr. Miller. He didn't think about his tapes, his promises, or his past self's warnings. The animal in him took over.

He shoved through the commuters, knocking shoulders, muttering frantic apologies as he fought the human tide.

"Wait!" he shouted, his voice cracking against the tiles of the ceiling. "Wait!"

The woman began walking up the concrete steps toward the street.

Evan vaulted the lower railing, his boots skidding on the wet terrazzo, his hand reaching out. He reached the landing, gripped the rough wool of her charcoal sleeve, and spun her around.

"Clara—"

The woman turned, her eyes wide with shock and terror.

She was fifty years old. Her face was lined with crow's feet around pale green eyes. She wore bright red lipstick, and her hair was dyed a brassy auburn that showed gray roots at the parting.

She yanked her arm back, clutching her drafting tube to her chest like a club.

"Get your hands off me!" she yelled, her voice shrill, echoing across the landing. "Back off!"

Two transit security officers at the top of the stairs turned their heads toward the noise, their hands dropping to their utility belts.

Evan stood on the wet concrete step, his hand hanging empty in the cold air.

The world dropped into terrifying, crystalline focus.

The commuters were staring at him—eyes full of judgment, disgust, and the cold suspicion reserved for madmen and predators.

"I'm sorry," Evan breathed, his chest heaving, the blood draining from his face until his lips were white. "I... I thought you were someone else."

He didn't wait for the transit guards to reach him. He spun on his heel, took the steps three at a time back down to the lower platform, and disappeared into the surging crowd of the westbound line.

He sat on the kitchen floor in the dark flat, his back braced against the locked deadbolt of door 4B.

He didn't turn on the lights. He didn't take off his wet boots.

His skull throbbed with a rhythmic, sickening pressure behind his left temple—a dull, hot iron pressing against his optic nerve. He could feel the friction of the synapses, the chemical blockers fighting a losing battle against the raw electrical current of his autonomic memory.

He was losing his grip on the edges. If he didn't go back to St. Jude, if he didn't take the shot, this wasn't going to end in noble grief.

It was going to end in a public breakdown. A police van. A psychiatric observation cell where he would spend days babbling about broken umbrellas and uncashed checks to doctors who would simply sign the committal papers.

He pulled the black notebook from his inside pocket.

His fingers were smeared with gray grease from the container yard. He flipped to the next page, using the sickly amber light from the streetlamp outside to guide the pen.

The ink dug so deep it almost pierced the paper:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 04.**

*The dam is leaking.*

*I saw her arm today at the yard.*

*I heard her voice on the train.*

*I grabbed a stranger on the platform and almost ended up in handcuffs.*

*Dr. Miller was right about the horror of it.*

*The mind doesn't rebuild what was lost.*

*It makes monsters out of the scraps.*

*I don't know what is real anymore.*

*Every dark coat looks like her.*

*Every smell of wood shavings makes my chest seize.*

*I am coming apart at the joints.*

*The sentry has lost his watch.*

*If I don't find a way to anchor this weight, the fall isn't going to kill the memories.*

*It is going to kill me.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

He capped the pen, let his head fall back against the wood of the door, and closed his eyes, listening to the phantom rain tapping against a window that had been closed for five months.

## CHAPTER 13

### THE BROKEN SENTRY

The body will tolerate an eviction of the heart, but it will not negotiate with physics.

By Thursday night, Evan had gone eighty-six hours without sleep. He had substituted coffee and cold tap water for food, drinking the black slurry until the lining of his stomach felt raw and acidic. Whenever his eyelids grew heavy, the cognitive static returned—the sound of wood shavings hitting floorboards, the smell of turpentine, the violent, concussive phantom pain behind his ribs.

Sleep was no longer an escape; it was an ambush. To avoid it, he volunteered for every graveyard standby shift the depot offered, taking double turnarounds in the wet, freezing dark of the rail transfer yard.

If he was moving iron, he was real. If his hands were blistered, he had a right to occupy space.

At 3:40 AM, the temperature over the concrete apron dropped to two degrees below freezing. Frost coated the yellow steel handrails of the staging gantry. Sleet blew in horizontal needles off the tidal marsh, turning the black asphalt slick under the halogen floodlights.

Evan stood on the lower platform of Bay 7, holding an iron tensioning lever, securing the high-tensile chains across a twenty-ton flatbed haul of structural steel.



His breath came in thin, ragged plumes. His fingers inside his wet leather work gloves were completely numb, the cold biting through to the bone.

*Lever down. Catch the dog. Pin the link.*

He threw his entire body weight into the iron handle.

The ratchet groaned, taking up the slack.

Then his left temple exploded with heat.

It wasn't a metaphor. It felt as if a copper wire had been laid directly across his brain tissue and hooked to a live generator. His vision flared blinding white, wiping out the gantry, the flatbed, the sleet.

In the blinding flash, he heard a sound—not the clanking of heavy rail freight, but the light, rhythmic click of a porcelain spoon stirring milk into tea.

*“Evan, you’re working the late turn again.”*

The voice did not come from his ears. It came from the base of his skull, clear, intimate, smelling of rain and warm flannel.

*“You don’t have to keep the watch anymore.”*

His motor control severed instantly.

The forty-pound steel lever slipped from his numb fingers. The high-tension ratchet snapped back with the explosive force of an artillery recoil, the iron handle slamming directly into his left collarbone.

The sound of cracking bone was dull, wet, and completely swallowed by the roar of the yard tractors.

Evan didn't feel the pain—not immediately. He felt the cold iron of the gantry deck rushing up to meet his cheek. He hit the frosted steel plate on

his side, his helmet clattering away across the apron, his legs tangled in the slack tie-down chains.

He lay staring at the underside of a sixty-foot flatbed chassis. Oil dripped from a differential housing, hitting the wet steel two inches from his eye.

*Drip. Drip. Drip.*

He tried to push himself up. His left arm refused the signal entirely, hanging loose and disjointed at his side. A violent shudder ripped through his core, his diaphragm seizing in a series of dry, desperate convulsions.

He couldn't get air into his lungs. The sky above the depot was spinning—a gray, violent whirlpool of halogen light and sleet.

Footsteps clattered hard down the iron ladder. Heavy boots splashed through the slush.

"Vance! Christ—man down at Bay Seven! Cut the hydraulic line! Call the yard medic!"

Hands grabbed his shoulders, rolling him onto his back. Cold sleet hit his forehead, mingling with the hot blood trickling from a split along his hairline where he had struck the decking.

He saw the yard foreman's face leaning over him, pale under the yellow glare of the lamps, mouth moving, shouting commands Evan could no longer decode into language.

Evan looked past the foreman's shoulder, up into the black winter sky.

The static was gone. The voices were gone.

For the first time in seven weeks, the noise in his skull stopped. The crushing, desperate urgency to prove he was necessary, the suffocating

terror of being unworthy of love unless he was bleeding for it—it all drained out of him onto the frozen steel deck like gray bilge water.

He was broken.

The sentry had abandoned the gate. The wall had crumbled.

And as the dark closed in around the edges of his vision, Evan felt an emotion so foreign, so utterly alien to his entire adult life, that a faint, broken breath escaped his lips:

Relief.

He woke twelve hours later to the smell of rubbing alcohol and industrial floor wax.

The room was narrow, illuminated by a pale rectangle of winter sunlight cutting through horizontal blinds. A white plastic sling immobilized his left arm against his chest. His collarbone was strapped tight beneath heavy elastic bandages, throbbing with a dull, throbbing ache that tasted like rusted iron.

Beside the metal examination bed sat a woman in a gray wool blazer, her silver hair pulled back into a severe clip.

Dr. Aris, the regional medical officer for the terminal authority.

She had an open manila folder on her lap. Beside it lay his company ID card, his security clearance transponder, and an official printed notice stamped with bold red ink.

"Fractured clavicle," Dr. Aris said, her voice flat, devoid of bedside theater. "Two cracked ribs on the left side. Mild concussion. But those are the simple injuries, Mr. Vance."

Evan looked at the ceiling tiles. He tried to swallow; his throat felt lined with sandpaper.

"The toxicology panel from the trauma ward came back an hour ago," she continued, tapping the edge of the folder with a gold pen. "Your blood work shows zero trace of narcotics or alcohol. But it shows an unprecedented concentration of un-stabilized neuro-inhibitor metabolites. St. Jude protocol markers."

Evan closed his eyes.

"I don't care what you do in your private life," the doctor said, leaning forward slightly. "I don't care whose memories you paid to have scrubbed out of your cortex. But operating heavy hydraulic tensioning gear while undergoing an active synaptic decoupling without clinical stabilization is gross operational negligence. You could have dropped that twenty-ton steel load onto the passenger tracks."

She reached out and placed the red-stamped document on the bedside tray, right beside his watch.

## **TERMINAL OPERATIONAL AUTHORITY**

### **MANDATORY      MEDICAL      DISQUALIFICATION      & ADMINISTRATIVE LEAVE**

*Duration: Indefinite (Minimum 90 Days)*

*Status: Suspended from Yard Operations / Access Revoked*

"Your badge is deactivated," Dr. Aris said, standing up and smoothing her blazer. "You are banned from the freight terminal grounds until you produce a signed certificate of neuro-cognitive stabilization from an accredited clinic. You have seventy-two hours to clear your personal belongings from the crew locker."

She paused by the door, looking back at him with an expression that was neither angry nor sympathetic—just the cold assessment of a mechanic looking at an engine block with a cracked cylinder.

"You're thirty-one years old, Evan. If you keep using your body as a battering ram to outrun whatever is in your head, the next time they call me, it will be to sign the death certificate."

The door clicked shut.

He returned to the flat in a taxi he couldn't afford.

The driver had to help him carry his small duffel bag of locker items up the four flights of concrete stairs. Evan fumbled with the brass keys with his right hand, his left arm pinned uselessly to his ribs under his heavy coat, every step sending a jolt of fire through his shoulder.

The flat was freezing.

He didn't turn on the radiators. He dropped the bag on the floor, kicked the door shut with the heel of his boot, and stood in the center of the living room.

The silence was absolute.

For five years, work had been his fortress. The overtime slips, the midnight yard shifts, the heavy diesel fumes, the physical exhaustion—they were the bricks he had piled high around himself so he wouldn't have to look Clara in the eye and admit he was terrified of being ordinary. He had used labor as an emotional shield, convincing himself that as long as his back was breaking, no one could accuse him of failing.

Now, the shield had been ripped away by a piece of corporate paper.

He had ninety days.

No sixty-ton cranes. No manifests. No night turns. No alarms ringing at four in the morning to pull him out of the cold sheets.

There was only this room.

There was only the worn wood of the floorboards, the uncashed checks from three years ago sitting on the table, and the framed woodcut hanging by the front door.

Evan walked over to the frame.

He stood before *The First Night*.

In the dim winter twilight, he looked at the man holding the broken umbrella. He looked at the locked jaw, the defensive shoulders, the terrifying arrogance of a man who thought he could stand between another human being and the sky.

"It's over," Evan whispered to the glass. "You lost the job."

He sat down on the floor beneath the frame, leaning his good shoulder against the plaster wall.

He pulled the black notebook from his coat with his right hand. It took him two minutes to work the elastic band free using his teeth and his good thumb. He balanced the notebook on his knee, uncapped the pen, and began to write.

His handwriting was uneven, crooked from the awkward angle and the pain radiating from his broken bone, but every letter was deliberate:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 05.**

*The machine finally broke.*

*My shoulder is snapped in half.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*They took my badge.*

*They locked me out of the yard.*

*For ten years, I thought a man was only worth what he could carry.*

*I thought if I stopped moving, the world would see that I had nothing else to give.*

*So I carried everything until the bone splintered through the skin.*

*I don't have a shift tomorrow.*

*I don't have a shift next week.*

*I have nowhere to hide.*

*Tomorrow, I am going back to the St. Jude Annex.*

*Not to get the shot.*

*Not to let Dr. Miller burn the roots.*

*I am going to get my file.*

*I want the intake transcripts.*

*I want to read the words I said before I cut her out of my head.*

*If I am going to live in this empty house, I am going to look at the blood on the floor.*

He let the pen fall onto the wood.

He rested his head against the cold wall, listening to the winter wind rattle the loose pane of the living room window, and for the first time in six weeks, he did not fight the dark when it came.

## CHAPTER 14

### THE RETURN TO ST. JUDE

The light-industrial belt looked grayer under a freezing November drizzle.

Evan arrived by midday bus, his left arm bound tight across his chest beneath his heavy wool coat. Every pothole on the access road sent a jolt of raw heat through his fractured collarbone, but the physical ache was a clean, localized thing. You could set a bone in plaster. You could measure the weeks until the calcium knit together.

It was the unmapped breaks that killed a man.

He pushed through the smoked-glass doors of the corporate park, walked past the silent import-export offices, and took the lift to the third floor.

The reception area of the St. Jude Neuro-Cognitive Annex was identical to his visit twelve days ago: the hum of the HVAC, the muted corporate carpet, the two patients staring into the middle distance like passengers waiting for a ferry that had already sailed.

The receptionist looked up from her curved acrylic desk. Her eyes flicked from the white sling supporting his arm to the purple contusion spreading across his left temple.

"Mr. Vance," she said, her voice registering a flicker of professional caution. "You don't have an appointment on the log."

"I need to see Dr. Miller," Evan said.

"Dr. Miller's consultation schedule is fully committed through—"



"Tell him I'm not here for the stabilization injection," Evan interrupted. His voice was low, rasping slightly from lack of water. "Tell him I'm here for the file."

She hesitated, her fingers hovering over a silent intercom key, before pressing the button and murmuring two sentences into her headset.

A minute later, the oak door to Suite 304 opened.

Dr. Miller stood in the aperture. He wore the same crisp white shirt, the same rimless spectacles, but when his eyes took in Evan's ruined posture—the sling, the dark circles carved deep into his eye sockets, the gray cast of his skin—his mouth tightened into a thin, knowing line.

"Come in, Evan," Miller said.

The door clicked shut behind them.

Miller did not take his seat behind the walnut table. He leaned against the windowsill, his arms folded across his chest, looking at Evan with the weary condescension of an engineer whose structural warning had gone unheeded.

"Terminal operations called our compliance desk yesterday morning," Miller said evenly. "They requested verification of an emergency psychiatric hold. I informed them that while your protocol was incomplete, you were legally competent when you signed the discharge waiver. I assume that sling is the result of the somatic drift we discussed?"

"A twenty-ton tensioner snapped back," Evan said. He sat down in the high-backed leather chair, easing his bruised back against the cushions. "Cracked the clavicle. Two ribs."

"You're fortunate you didn't sever an artery," Miller said, reaching toward the brushed-steel cabinet beneath the window. He laid his palm against the

small black case holding the titanium injector. "The offer remains open. The lipid antagonist is still viable. A single subcutaneous dose will quiet the autonomic loop. The seizures, the cognitive leakage, the phantom panic—they will flatline within thirty-six hours."

"I didn't come for the shot."

Miller's hand remained on the case. "Then why are you here, Mr. Vance? To demand a refund on a completed surgical procedure?"

"I want the intake transcripts," Evan said. "The audio from July. Before the first session."

Miller frowned, the clinical neutrality slipping for a fraction of a second into annoyance.

"Intake evaluations are proprietary clinical records. Under the Non-Disclosure Rider you signed on July 14, all subjective contextual material is sealed to prevent retroactive cognitive feedback. Reading your own intake file while the suppression is active could induce an acute dissociative episode."

"I know what I signed," Evan said, leaning forward. His right hand went into his coat pocket, withdrew a folded white document, and laid it flat on the walnut table.

It was the notice from the terminal authority, stamped with the red seal of indefinite suspension.

"I've already lost my clearance," Evan said, his gaze locked on the doctor's eyes. "My job is gone. The woman is gone. I have an empty flat, a broken shoulder, and ninety days of silence. You told me the brain despises an empty shelf. Well, my shelf is bare, Miller. If I don't know why I climbed

onto this operating table, I'm going to spend the next ten years tearing this city apart looking for a ghost."

Miller looked down at the red-stamped suspension notice. He tapped his thumb against his forefinger, calculating the legal and administrative liabilities in silence.

Finally, he gave a short, resigned sigh.

"Wait here."

The doctor disappeared through an interior door into the record archives.

Three minutes later, he returned carrying a slim cardboard folio bound with a red fabric tie. He did not hand it over. He sat in the opposite chair, untied the ribbon, and drew out a single printed transcript running three pages, stamped in red ink across the top margin: **PRE-OPERATIVE CLINICAL INTERVIEW / SUBJECT: VANCE, E.**

"I will not release the raw audio," Miller said strictly. "Auditory triggers are too volatile for an un-stabilized temporal cortex. You may read the transcription of your own closing statement from the preliminary assessment. Nothing more."

He slid the three sheets of paper across the wood.

Evan's right hand hovered over the text. The paper was crisp, bearing the watermark of the St. Jude Foundation. The date at the top was July 19. Four months ago.

He found his own words halfway down the second page:

**DR. MILLER:** *The procedure is irreversible, Mr. Vance. Once the synaptic decoupling is finalized, semantic retrieval of the subject is*

*permanently degraded. Why not simply separate? Move to another district. Allow time to do the work naturally.*

**SUBJECT (VANCE):** *Because she won't let me go. And worse than that—I won't let her leave.*

**DR. MILLER:** *Clarify that.*

**SUBJECT (VANCE):** *She was offered a life. In Rotterdam. A real life, where she isn't spending her weekends washing grease out of my work trousers and watching me calculate the price of eggs. She's an artist, Dr. Miller. When she looks at an iron fence, she sees the way the rust catches the morning light. When I look at it, I just calculate what it would cost to haul it to the scrapyard.*

*I've spent five years convincing myself that if I worked until my lungs bled, I was loving her. But I wasn't loving her. I was holding her hostage with my own misery. Every time she tries to pay a bill, I treat it like an insult. Every time she offers me an out, I dig my heels into the mud and drag her down with me, because my pathetic, terrified pride can't stand the idea of being the one who needed saving.*

**DR. MILLER:** *And you believe this procedure solves that dynamic?*

**SUBJECT (VANCE):** *If I tell her to leave, she will stay out of pity. If I pack my bag and walk out, she will spend the next three years waiting by the phone, blaming herself, thinking she didn't sacrifice enough. She is too good for this world, and she is far too good for me.*

*The only way she survives is if I become a stone. If I look at her and she sees nothing. If she realizes that the man who promised to wait on the beach has simply turned into cold dirt.*

*Make me forget her, Miller. Take the tram stop. Take the songs. Take the way she looks when she's carving wood under the lamp. Take all of it.*

*I don't deserve the memories. And she doesn't deserve to spend the rest of her youth nursing an anchor.*

Evan stopped reading.

The suite was dead silent save for the faint, steady rattle of sleet against the third-floor window.

He stared at the black ink on the page.

There was no sudden flood of lost images. No cinematic breakthrough. The tram stop remained a void. Her face remained an unpainted canvas. The clinic's chemicals had done their work with terrifying, irreversible precision; the neurons were cut, and the past was an ash heap.

Yet reading his own words from four months ago, the terrible fog of mystery evaporated, replaced by a brutal, blinding light.

He wasn't a victim of an uncanny curse. He wasn't a tragic hero caught in a supernatural machine.

He was simply a proud, terrified man who had built a prison out of his own martyrdom, and when the walls began to crack, he had chosen to lobotomize his own soul rather than admit he was too weak to carry his share of the light.

"Does it satisfy your curiosity?" Miller asked quietly.

Evan did not look up from the paper. "Can it be undone?"

"No," Miller said. The word was absolute, devoid of malice. "The neural pruning is structural. Even if the suppression degrades further, those

pathways will not regenerate their original data. You cannot rebuild a bridge after you have pulverized the stone into dust."

Miller pointed once more to the black case on the windowsill.

"Which brings us back to the only logical question left: do you want the stabilizer, Evan? You know the truth now. Carrying the phantom won't bring her back. It will only destroy your body, as it nearly did yesterday."

Evan slowly pushed the three sheets of paper back across the table.

He stood up, using his right hand to steady himself against the arm of the chair. The pain in his broken collarbone throbbed in slow, heavy waves, perfectly synchronized with his heartbeat.

"No," Evan said.

Miller frowned deeply. "You're choosing chronic neuropathy. You're choosing insomnia, panic, and phantom grief for a woman you will never recognize again."

"I am," Evan said.

He reached for the door handle.

"Why?" Miller demanded, his professional composure cracking into genuine bewilderment. "What possible utility is there in holding onto an ache for a person who doesn't exist to you?"

Evan paused with his hand on the cold aluminum lever.

He thought of the uncashed checks in the bottom of the wardrobe. He thought of the framed print hanging by the door—the man holding the broken umbrella, terrified of needing anyone.

"Because she's out there," Evan said softly. "Somewhere in this world, carrying the weight of what we were, entirely alone. If I take your shot, she's the only one left holding the bill."

He met the doctor's eyes one last time.

"I won't let her carry it alone. Even if all I have left to offer is the cold."

He opened the door and walked out into the corridor, leaving Dr. Miller sitting alone in Suite 304 with the unsealed file.

He reached the flat as the evening streetlamps flickered to life along the canal.

He did not sit in the dark.

For the first time in six weeks, Evan turned on the overhead lamp in the living room. He walked over to the radiator valve, gripped the cold iron handle with his right hand, and twisted it until the pipes groaned and hot water began to hiss through the cast-iron ribs.

He set his duffel bag in the bedroom. He took off his heavy coat, hanging it neatly on the wooden peg beneath Clara's print.

He walked into the kitchen, turned on the tap, and filled a single glass with cold water, drinking it down in three long, clean swallows.

Then he carried the black hardback notebook to the kitchen table.

He sat down beneath the yellow bulb. He opened to the first blank page in the second half of the book, uncapped his ballpoint pen with his teeth, and balanced the paper against his right forearm.

He began the final entry of Act II:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 06.**

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*I read the file today.*

*I saw what I said to Miller in July.*

*I wanted to be a stone so she wouldn't have to carry an anchor.*

*It was the most arrogant lie of my life.*

*The memories are dead.*

*Miller confirmed it: there is no magic restoration. No sudden dawn where the past comes rushing back. The tram stop is gone forever. Her name will never belong to me again.*

*I accept the terms.*

*The sentry has left the wall.*

*The fortress is abandoned.*

*Starting tomorrow, I am going to learn how to live inside an empty house without burning down the neighborhood.*

He closed the notebook, smoothed the black cloth cover with his palm, and for the first time since the first Sunday in October, he lay down on his mattress and let the sleep take him, welcoming the quiet room for exactly what it was.



## CHAPTER 15

### AN UNLOCKED DOOR

The snow arrived in the second week of December, falling in thick, quiet flakes that muffled the clatter of the port and turned the brick courtyards into blind white quadrangles.

Evan learned the geography of the flat with one good arm.

A fractured clavicle heals with a stubborn, thick callus—a knot of new bone like a weld over an iron pipe. In the beginning, putting on a heavy winter coat required five minutes of swearing through clenched teeth in the hallway. Tying bootlaces with one hand was an exercise in humiliating patience.

He didn't hire help. He didn't call the warehouse.

For the first time since he was eighteen, his days were empty of quotas, shipping lanes, and diesel exhaust. The ninety-day suspension sat on the bureau, its red ink fading under the pale winter sun, but it had ceased to feel like a sentence. It had become a clearing.

When a man has defined himself for a decade solely by what he can carry, laying the load down makes him feel weightless to the point of nausea. In the first three weeks, Evan paced the floorboards like an animal in a transit cage. He would stand at the window at four in the morning, his nerves firing phantom alerts to put his boots on, to beat the freeze, to sign the manifests.

Then, around the solstice, the frantic twitching in his limbs began to subside.

He stopped running the invisible engine.

In January, the orthopedic sling came off.

His left shoulder was stiff, the muscle wasted down to gray string, but the bone was solid. The doctor at the clinic gave him three rubber resistance bands and told him to begin stretching twice a day.

He started fixing the flat.

Not with the frantic, defensive aggression of a man preparing for a siege, but with the quiet, slow labor of someone paying an overdue debt to the room he occupied.

He bought a small can of brass polish and a dry rag. He spent an afternoon cleaning the tarnished handles on the hall wardrobe, rubbing away three years of grime until the pale metal gleamed under the bulb. He bought a box of washers from the ironmonger on the corner, took an adjustable spanner to the kitchen tap, and replaced the perished rubber valve that had been dripping into the stainless-steel sink since August.

When he tightened the brass packing nut and turned the stopcock, the dripping stopped.

The kitchen was silent. Not dead—just quiet.

Next, he took the heavy archive carton labeled **RECORDS** onto the narrow concrete balcony overlooking the alleyway.

He did not bring the ledger of expenses back inside. He took a galvanized zinc wash bucket, a box of long matches, and the six uncashed checks Clara had written him three years ago for the heating and the groceries.

He sat on a folding stool in the freezing air, his breath rising in white plumes against the gray brick.

He picked up the first check. *Pay to the order of Evan Vance. One hundred and eighty dollars. For the heating.*

He didn't read it with bitter shame anymore. He read it as a message sent from an equal partner who had loved him enough to offer him shelter.

He struck a match. The flame flared sulfur-yellow against the frost.

He touched the fire to the corner of the faded pink paper. The flame caught, turning the blue ink black, curling the check into gray ash that drifted down into the bottom of the zinc bucket.

He burned all six.

He burned the loan rejections, the frantic overtime tally sheets, and the angry pencil calculations on the cardboard flaps. He did not burn them out of malice, or to erase the history; he burned them because the war was over, and there was no sense in preserving the ammunition.

When the smoke cleared, he tipped the ashes into the snow-filled alley below and brought the empty bucket inside.

By February, the somatic drift had changed its character.

Dr. Miller had predicted madness. He had warned of unresolvable panic, of a mind eating itself in the dark.

The doctor had understood the chemistry of the brain, but he had understood nothing about grief.

The panic attacks did not disappear, but they lost their razor edges. When Evan woke at three in the morning to an empty bed, his chest still

tightened, his lungs still hitched—but he no longer fell onto the floorboards expecting the walls to collapse.

He simply lay in the dark, feeling the cold hollow beside his ribs, and let it stay.

*This is the price*, he would tell himself, staring at the gray ceiling. *You don't get to run from the bill.*

He did not lock the front door.

Every night since they had moved into flat 4B, Evan had turned the brass deadbolt twice, tested the handle with three hard yanks, and fastened the safety chain. It was the sentry's nightly sacrament: verifying that the perimeter was secure.

In mid-February, standing by the coat rack beneath Clara's framed woodcut, he took his hand off the deadbolt.

He left the lock open. Just the simple brass latch clicked into the strike plate.

If the storm wanted to come inside, let it come. A man cannot live his entire life behind iron plating and still expect to feel the sun when it finally breaks through the clouds.

On the last Sunday of February, he went into the spare room.

The guest alcove had remained shut since the night she took her cardboard cartons down the stairwell. He turned the handle, pushed the door open, and stepped into the small square of pale daylight.

The room smelled faintly of dust and old canvas.

He set up her drafting table near the window. He wiped down the tilted wood, clearing away the flakes of dried India ink and graphite shavings. In

the center of the clean surface, he laid the silver Olympus micro-cassette recorder, along with all seven tapes, stacked neatly in numerical order:

**01 – ARRIVAL**

**02 – THE SOUND**

**03 – THE FIRST MARK**

**04 – THE COVENANT**

**05 – THE RUPTURE**

**06 – THE CONTOUR**

**07 – THE CLEAN SLATE**

He didn't hide them in a locked drawer. He didn't smash them with a hammer.

They were artifacts of an execution he had survived. They belonged in the light, where they could do no more damage.

He pulled the black hardback notebook from his pocket, laid it on the drafting table beside the tapes, and opened to the next clean page.

His left arm had regained enough strength to hold the paper flat while his right hand guided the pen. The handwriting was no longer jagged and panicked; the strokes were steady, even, taking their time across the unlined white paper:

**POST-PROTOCOL. ENTRY 07.**

*The snow is melting off the eaves.*

*The radiator stopped banging.*

*I fixed the tap in the kitchen with a thirty-cent brass washer.*

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*I burned the checks today.*

*Not because they didn't matter, but because I don't need a ledger to remember that I was loved.*

*The door is unlocked tonight.*

*The watch is over.*

*I don't know who she is.*

*If she walked past me on the street this afternoon, my eyes would see only a coat and a face I do not possess.*

*The clinic took her features, her name, and the sound of her laugh.*

*They took the tram stop and the broken umbrella.*

*They took everything they were paid to take.*

*What they couldn't take was the quiet she left behind.*

*And for the first time in five years, I think I am strong enough to sit in it.*

He closed the notebook, left it lying beside the silver recorder, and walked back out into the living room, leaving the door to the alcove wide open to the rest of the house.

## CHAPTER 16

### THE EXHIBITION

Water Street ran parallel to the old barge canals, paved with dark cobblestones that stayed damp long after the afternoon rain had cleared.

Number 14 was a converted ironworks. The building had kept its soot-stained red brick exterior and its high arched industrial windows, but inside, the heavy timber trusses had been sandblasted clean and the brick had been painted a blinding, chalky white. Halogen track lighting hummed softly from the rafters, casting sharp, museum-grade pools of illumination across the polished concrete floor.

Evan arrived at twenty past six.

He had bought a clean white poplin shirt from the discount dry goods shop near the depot. It fit slightly stiff across his chest, the collar pressing against his collarbone where the knot of new bone sat beneath his skin like an iron marble. He wore his dark trousers, his boots polished with black grease until the scuffs disappeared, and no coat.

He stepped over the brass threshold into the room.

The gallery smelled of dry paper, white emulsion, and expensive perfume cut with the sharp, faint ghost of mineral spirits. Thirty or forty people were already moving between the partitions—men in unstructured linen suits, women in architectural glasses holding narrow flutes of cheap prosecco, speaking in the hushed, performative whispers of people who treated art like an investment seminar.

None of them looked at him. To them, he was an invisible demographic: a quiet man with broad shoulders and calloused knuckles, standing with his hands clasped behind his back like a night watchman who had wandered onto the wrong shift.

Near the entrance, mounted directly to the white drywall in matte black vinyl lettering, was the curator's statement:

**CLARA LIN: THE HOURS WE KEPT**

*A retrospective of relief prints, woodcuts, and copper proofs (Year One - Year Five).*

*"Memory is not a recording; it is an act of construction. When the physical archive fails or is willfully destroyed, the printmaker becomes an archaeologist of the living. These thirty-two plates represent a private history carved out of pearwood and cherry, documenting the architecture of endurance, domestic labor, and the slow, quiet erosion of a shared perimeter."*

Beneath the text sat a small timber plinth holding a stack of printed exhibition catalogs.

Evan took one. The paper was heavy matte card. He didn't read the essays. He turned past the artist's statement to the floor plan.

The exhibition had been laid out in a continuous, counter-clockwise labyrinth. Three free-standing partition walls directed the viewer through a strict chronological progression:

- *Part I: The Ground We Stood On*
- *Part II: The Ironing Board & The Ledger*
- *Part III: The Winter Turn*



- *Part IV: The Empty House*

Evan walked toward the first alcove.

His steps made no sound on the polished concrete. His chest felt tight, the air thin in his throat, but the violent tremor that used to plague his fingers was entirely absent. He was not looking for an escape anymore. He was a man walking into the reading of a will he had already signed.

The prints in *Part I* were small, delicate, pulled on warm, fibrous handmade papers.

There was the corner of 4th and Elm: the green tram awning, rendered in dizzying, vertical cuts of rain, the rails reflecting the sodium-vapor lamps like molten lead.

Beside it hung an interior study: a battered electric kettle sitting on a chipped laminate counter, steam curling toward a peeling strip of ceiling paper in long, sweeping gouges of the blade.

Beside that: two pairs of socks drying over the iron ribs of a radiator.

Evan stood in front of the radiator print for three full minutes.

He did not remember the day she carved it. He did not know what month it had been. But he recognized the dent in the floorboard beneath the valve—the exact depression where his heel dug in when he knelt to bleed the air from the pipes every autumn.

She hadn't painted their love as a grand, sweeping romance. There were no melodramatic embraces, no heroic gestures, no gilded frames.

She had carved their life as a sequence of small, stubborn acts of physical survival. She had documented the way they had leaned against the world: the tea bags drying on a saucer to be used a second time, the pile of yellow

overtime slips under a glass paperweight, the dent in the mattress where a body turned in the dark.

She had seen everything.

While he had been standing in the cold yard, convinced that he was the only sentry guarding the perimeter, she had been sitting in the guest room under an anglepoise lamp, meticulously recording every single brick he had laid down between them.

Evan moved into the second alcove.

*Part II: The Ironing Board & The Ledger.*

The prints here were larger, forty centimeters across, pulled on stark, brilliant white rag that gave the black ink a brutal, graphic weight.

The first was titled: *Refusal No. 1 (The Heating)*.

It was a woodcut of his own hands.

The perspective was from across the kitchen table. The print showed two heavy, male forearms resting on the laminate, fingers curled into tight, defensive fists over a stack of blue utility envelopes. The veins stood out along the wrist with microscopic accuracy. Tucked half-under his left knuckle was the corner of a personal check, pushed aside like a contaminated rag.

Beneath the title, in the exhibition catalog, was a single line of printed text from the artist's notes:

*Plate 14. Pearwood.*

*"He would rather freeze with his pride intact than allow a woman to buy the firewood."*

Evan felt a dull, heavy thud behind his ribs.

He didn't look away. He forced his eyes to track every stroke of the gouge, every thin white line where she had peeled the wood away to reveal the stubborn, locked rigidity of his posture.

She hadn't hated him for it. If she had hated him, the lines would have been rough, jagged, dismissive. But the carving was tender—agony rendered with surgical, unhurried care. She had loved him enough to understand the precise nature of the poison that was killing him.

He turned the corner into the third partition: *The Winter Turn*.

The room opened up. At the far end of the gallery, three oversized prints were hung against a free-standing wall painted deep, charcoal gray.

In front of the central print, a knot of people had gathered. A young man with a leather messenger bag was leaning in close, inspecting the grain of the paper, speaking to a woman in a heavy wool shawl.

"The technical discipline is unbelievable," the man murmured. "Look at the reduction technique on the jacket. She had to print that black four times to get that density."

The woman nodded. "Who was he? Did she ever say?"

"Nobody knows," the man replied, thumbing through his catalog. "The gallery director said she spent six months in Rotterdam working on the proofs, but the subject never showed up to any of the European previews. An old flame from the docks, probably."

The couple moved on toward the wine table.

Evan walked forward until he stood in the exact center of the charcoal wall.

The print was thirty-six by forty-eight inches.

It was titled: *The Clean Slate*.

The perspective was from the hallway of flat 4B, looking into the small living room on a Sunday morning.

A man sat on the sagging sofa beneath the window. His elbows rested on his knees, his chin dropped toward his chest, his hands hanging limp and open between his boots. The morning light poured through the bare glass, throwing his shadow long and dark across the bare floorboards.

His face had not been carved.

Where the eyes, the nose, the mouth should have been, the wood had been hollowed out with a wide, flat chisel—a smooth, clean, unblemished oval of raw white paper.

An empty vessel. A man who had erased his own features so he wouldn't have to watch the house burn.

And on the low coffee table in front of him sat a tiny, perfectly rendered object, no larger than an inch on the print:

A silver Olympus micro-cassette recorder, with seven small rectangles stacked neatly beside the casing.

Evan stared at the hollow face on the paper.

The room around him faded. The chatter of the patrons, the clinking of wine glasses, the hum of the track lights—they all washed away into the low, rhythmic whisper of an old tide receding over cold gravel.

She had known everything.

From the very first week. From the day he couldn't remember the tram stop. From the moment he bought the notebook and hid the tapes behind the splintered drawer.

She had watched him build his machine of erasure day by day, Sunday by Sunday, and instead of fighting him, instead of screaming at a man who was already halfway through the trapdoor, she had picked up her gouges and carved his suicide note into wood so that the world would know he had existed.

"Evan?"

The voice did not come from a micro-cassette.

It did not come from the back of his skull, or from the phantom hum of an un-stabilized temporal pathway.

It came from three paces behind his right shoulder.

Soft. Hesitant. Bearing the faint, rough timbre of someone who had spent the last eight hours breathing in dry paper and turpentine.

Evan did not turn around immediately.

He stood in front of the hollow man on the charcoal wall, took one long, slow breath into his mended ribs, and let his hands drop to his sides.

Then, slowly, he turned to face the stranger.

## CHAPTER 17

### THE SILHOUETTE

When Evan turned, his optic nerve registered a set of physical dimensions: five feet four inches, shoulders square, hair cut blunt and dark against the pale nape of her neck. She wore a tailored black boiler suit, rolled at the cuffs, and flat canvas plimsolls dusted with dry chalk.

Her face was thirty inches from his.

He looked into her eyes. They were dark brown, the color of wet river stones, set beneath straight, unplucked brows. A faint, silver crescent scar marked the knuckle of her left index finger where she held a half-empty tumbler of water.

He waited for the lightning strike. He waited for the sudden, miraculous re-ignition of five years of domestic history to tear through the scar tissue of his temporal lobe.

Nothing ignited.

The clinical suppression held its ground like concrete. She was not a memory. She was an absolute, terrifying stranger standing in a room full of strangers.

And yet, looking at her, his sternum tightened with that familiar, bruising ache—the deep, dull pull of a gravity his mind could not explain. The phantom limb was singing against the bone.

Clara did not step back.

She stood frozen on the polished concrete, her water glass gripped so tightly that the skin across her knuckles went chalk-white. Her dark eyes darted across his features with frantic, forensic urgency: tracking the white line of the scar through his left eyebrow, the knot of new bone bulging under the collar of his white poplin shirt, and finally settling on his pupils.

She was searching for the light.

She was looking for the blank, terrifying vacancy from Day 6—the look of a dead man staring through an open doorway.

"Evan," she whispered again. It was barely a breath, fragile as torn silk.

"Hello, Clara," he said.

At the sound of her name, her shoulders hitched inward, a small, involuntary flinch of shock. A tremor went through her chin, her lips parting as she tried to reconcile the man standing before her with the ghost she had buried in Rotterdam six months ago.

"You know my name," she said, her voice dropping into a register so low it was completely swallowed by the chatter of the patrons behind them.

"I found the card," Evan said, his voice level, steady, stripped of the defensive static that had choked him for five years. He reached into his trouser pocket, drew out the square exhibition postcard with its torn corner, and held it out between them. "Outside the bakery on the footbridge."

Clara looked at the crumpled paper. She did not take it.

"The clinic said the nominal anchor was permanent," she said, her eyes rising back to his face. "Miller told me... when I called their legal desk from Holland in November to confirm the lease transfer, they said you were in Phase Two."

"I walked out," Evan said. "I didn't take the lipid."

A sharp, audible intake of air hissed through her teeth. Her gaze dropped instantly to his left shoulder—to the unnatural angle of his clavicle beneath the thin cotton of his shirt, the faint stiffness in the way his arm hung at his flank.

"Your arm," she breathed.

"Tensioning chain snapped at the yard," he said simply. "Three ribs, too. They healed."

"You idiot," she whispered. The word carried no venom; it was saturated with a profound, staggering grief that seemed to collapse the three feet of space between them. "You complete, arrogant idiot. Miller told you what would happen if you didn't stabilize. He told you the nervous system would rip itself apart."

"It tried," Evan said. He looked over her shoulder, toward the charcoal wall where the white, faceless oval of *The Clean Slate* hung under the halogen spotlight. "For about three months, the house felt like a live wire. I made tea for two people every night. I spilled half a teaspoon of sugar onto the counter because my hand wouldn't stop reaching for a mug that wasn't there."

A single tear broke from Clara's lower eyelid, tracking slowly down her cheek, catching the hard white light of the gallery. She did not raise a hand to wipe it away.

"Why are you here, Evan?" she asked, her voice cracking on his name. "What are you looking for? There's nothing left to take back. You paid eighty thousand dollars to turn five years into ashes. You don't get to walk through my gallery and look at the smoke."



"I didn't come to take anything back," Evan said.

He stepped half an inch closer. Not to invade her space, but to anchor himself against the noise of the room. A patron in a rust-colored jacket brushed past them, murmuring an apology, entirely oblivious to the fact that he had just walked through an open grave.

"I came because of the woodcut you left behind," Evan said. "The one with the umbrella."

Clara looked at him, her dark eyes wide, searching.

"I framed it," he said. "It's hanging by the front door. Right across from the coat rack."

"Why would you do that?" she asked, a bitter, defensive edge rising in her throat. "If you don't even know who carved it?"

"Because every morning when I leave that flat, I look at the man in the rain," Evan said, his voice dropping into an intimate, unhurried cadence. "And I see what a coward looks like. I see a man who thought that if he took all the cold onto his own back, it made him noble. I see a man who was so terrified of being ordinary that he starved the woman he loved of a real partner, just so he could keep playing the martyr."

Clara stood entirely motionless. The glass in her hand tilted slightly, water lapping near the rim.

"I burned the checks, Clara," he continued quietly. "All six of them. Out on the balcony in the snow. And I read your spreadsheet for Rotterdam. The twelve hundred euros. The half you marked to wire back for the lease."

He looked directly into her eyes—stranger's eyes, yet infinitely familiar to his marrow.

"You weren't running from me. You were trying to build a bridge so we didn't both drown in the mud. And I crushed it because my pride was too small to let you help row the boat."

Clara closed her eyes. Her head dropped forward, her chin touching the collar of her black suit. A shudder ran through her slender frame, her knuckles finally giving up their white-hot grip on the tumbler.

"Do you know who I am?" she asked, her voice muffled against her chest. "Right now. Looking at my face. Do you know who I am, Evan?"

Evan took a slow breath.

The honest answer was the hardest thing he had ever spoken.

"No," he said.

The syllable hung between them, clean and terrible.

"I don't remember the tram stop," Evan said softly. "I don't remember the song on the vinyl. I don't remember what your mouth felt like on the fire escape, or the silversmith in the cargo container. When I look at your face right now, my brain sees a woman I have never met before in my life."

Clara flinched, but she did not look away. She raised her head, tears spilling freely over her cheeks now, glistening in the cool gallery light.

"Then why are you crying?" she asked.

Evan raised his right hand to his own face.

His fingers came away wet.

He hadn't realized the tears were falling. There had been no warning hitch in his throat, no theatrical sob. Just the quiet, somatic overflow of a body

that had carried an unpayable debt through a long, freezing winter, finally standing before the creditor with empty hands.

"Because the doctor was wrong about one thing," Evan whispered, looking down at her ink-stained knuckles. "He said if you cut the wires, the house becomes empty. But it isn't empty, Clara. It's just quiet."

He looked around the white room, taking in the thirty-two woodcut plates—the radiators, the tea mugs, the uncashed checks, the empty hallways—the monumental archive of devotion she had pulled from raw pearwood while he had been hiding behind his overtime slips.

"You made a beautiful life out of what we were," Evan said, his voice steadying. "I just wanted to see it once. To tell you that you were right. You were right about everything."

He stepped back two paces, clearing the perimeter, giving her back the air she had earned.

"I won't bother you again," he said quietly. "Congratulations on the show, Clara. The work is magnificent."

He turned on the polished concrete and began walking toward the heavy brass doors of the Foundry Gallery, his hands loose at his sides, ready to step back out into the cold damp of Water Street.

"Evan."

Her voice cut through the murmur of the room, sharper this time, carrying the old, familiar ring of a woman who had never allowed him to have the last word.

Evan stopped near the threshold. He turned.

Clara was standing where he had left her, the crowd parting slightly around her black silhouette. She had set her glass down on a nearby plinth.

"The gallery closes at eight," she said. Her voice was trembling, but her chin was lifted, defiant against the white drywall. "There's an all-night diner three doors down. The one with the green neon sign by the canal."

She wiped her cheeks with the back of her sleeve, leaving a faint streak of chalk across her temple.

"I take my tea with half a teaspoon of sugar," she said, looking straight into his unfamiliar eyes. "And barely enough milk to cloud the surface. Don't be late."

## CHAPTER 18

### THE CORNER BOOTH

The green neon sign buzzed with a low, wet hum, casting an oily emerald sheen over the puddle at the curb.

#### *THE CANAL DOCK DINER.*

Inside, the air was warm and smelled of fried onions, stale coffee grinds, and floor polish. A long counter of yellowed Formica ran the length of the narrow room, backed by spinning vinyl stools with patched seams. At twenty past eight, the place was mostly empty—a night-shift tugboat pilot reading a tabloid at the counter, a waitress in a stained pink apron wiping down the pie carousel.

Evan sat in the booth furthest from the door, wedged into a corner beneath a rain-streaked window overlooking the dark water of the barge canal.

On the table between the two red vinyl bench seats sat two heavy ceramic mugs.

One held black coffee, steaming faintly. The other held hot water, an orange pekoe tea bag resting on the saucer, a small glass pitcher of milk, and a stainless-steel spoon sitting beside a bowl of white granulated sugar.

He didn't touch the sugar. He didn't want to measure it before she arrived; he wanted her to see that he had listened, but had not presumed to make it for her.

The brass bell above the door jangled.

Evan looked up.

Clara stepped through the doorway, shaking out an umbrella that was black, functional, and intact. She had changed out of her chalk-dusted work suit into dark wool trousers and an oversized moss-green cardigan with deep patch pockets. Her damp hair was tucked behind her ears.

She scanned the room, saw him in the back corner, and paused for three seconds.

In that pause, Evan saw the hesitation—the instinct of a woman approaching an unexploded shell. She didn't know if the man at the table would glitch, if he would look through her with vacant eyes, or if the conversation at the gallery had been the dying spasm of a severed nerve.

Then she walked over, slid into the opposite bench, and folded her hands on the table.

Her fingers were still stained with black ink around the cuticle beds. A faint scent of linseed oil and cedar cut through the diner's grease.

"You're on time," she said.

"Seven minutes early," Evan replied.

She looked down at the table. She saw the hot water, the orange pekoe tea bag, the milk, the sugar bowl.

Her mouth softened into a faint, wry line that Evan's brain could not remember, but that his chest recognized with an ache like bruised bone.

"You didn't fix it," she said.

"I didn't want to get the milk wrong," Evan said honestly. "I know the words. 'Barely enough to cloud the surface.' But I don't know what that looks like in your cup."

Clara reached out, dropped the tea bag into the water, and let it steep until the pale amber deepened into red-brown. She lifted the small glass pitcher, tipped three drops of milk into the brew—just enough to turn the liquid from copper to caramel—and stirred in half a spoonful of sugar with a quiet, practiced chime of steel against ceramic.

She set the spoon down on the paper napkin.

"It looks like this," she said.

Evan looked at the mug. He nodded once, committing the shade to memory the way he used to log container manifests.

"Now I know," he said.

They sat in silence for a minute, listening to the muffled hiss of a passing car on the wet asphalt outside and the rhythmic clatter of cutlery from the kitchen. It was not the suffocating silence of flat 4B in November; it was the quiet of two survivors sitting on the wreckage of a raft, waiting to see which way the current was running.

Clara wrapped both hands around the warm mug, letting the heat sink into her fingers.

"Rotterdam was raining," she said abruptly.

Evan looked up from his black coffee. "Was it?"

"The whole four months," she said, staring out the window at the dark water where the green neon wavered like a severed ribbon. "A freezing, sleeting north-wind rain that made the wood blocks swell in the racks. The academy gave me a studio on the top floor of a converted dry dock. I had sixty square meters of space. Heated floors. A German reduction press that cost more than your flat."

She took a small sip of her tea, her throat working against the swallow.

"I sat in that studio for three weeks, Evan. Looking at thirty blank blocks of pearwood. I had all the light in the world. I had the stipend. I had no bills to pay, no landlord knocking on the door, no late notices from the utility company."

She turned her dark eyes back to him, raw and uncompromising.

"And every time I picked up the gouge, the only thing I could hear was the click of that damn deadbolt in the hallway. I could see you standing at the sink, measuring instant coffee with your hands shaking from sixty hours of shift work, convincing yourself that if you dropped dead on the gantry, you'd finally be a good provider."

Evan felt his knuckles tighten under the table.

"I was an idiot," he said.

"You were worse than an idiot," Clara said, her voice dropping into a fierce, low whisper that made the waitress by the pie counter glance over. "You were a tyrant of suffering. You took our life, and you made it into a private monument to your own endurance. You wouldn't let me be poor with you, Evan. You wouldn't let me be angry with you. You wouldn't even let me pay for the damn heat."

"I know," Evan whispered.

"Do you?" she demanded, leaning across the Formica. "Because from where I was standing in Rotterdam, reading Miller's clinical notice that you were undergoing a voluntary Seven-Day suppression, it didn't look like understanding. It looked like you were spitting in my face. You couldn't handle the fact that I saw your weakness, so you paid eighty thousand dollars to erase my eyes."



Evan took a slow breath. He didn't look down. He held her gaze, letting the accusations land where they belonged—right against the thick, mended bone of his left collarbone.

"I didn't erase you to hide my weakness, Clara," he said.

"Then why?"

"Because you wouldn't leave," he said simply.

Clara froze. The anger in her eyes flickered, caught off-guard by the flatness of the truth.

"You wouldn't have left," Evan continued, his voice steady as iron. "If I had stayed the way I was—broken, bitter, working eighty hours a week until my heart gave out—you would have stayed right beside me. You would have turned down Rotterdam. You would have taken a framing job in the market, washed my grease trousers, and watched me slowly rot in that kitchen. Because you loved me enough to let yourself be destroyed."

He leaned forward, his forearms resting on the laminate, fingers uncurled and open.

"I was a coward for a lot of things. I was a coward about money. I was a coward about pride. But when I signed the intake paper at St. Jude, it wasn't because I wanted to forget you. It was because turning myself into a monster was the only lever heavy enough to pry your fingers off the edge of the pit."

Clara stared at him.

The color drained from her cheeks, leaving her face pale beneath the harsh diner lighting. The anger that had held her spine erect for six months seemed to leak out of her in one long, trembling exhale.

She looked down at his hands on the table—the blunt knuckles, the faded grease stains that soap never fully washed out of the skin, the white scar across the thumb.

"Did it hurt?" she asked. The fire was gone from her voice, replaced by a terrible, quiet grief. "The seven days."

"The first three didn't," Evan said. "I thought it was just fatigue. By Day 4, when you brought the ring out, I knew the house was coming down. Day 6 was the worst."

Clara's eyes lifted back to his face. "When you looked at me."

"I saw a stranger in my living room," Evan said, his chest hitching slightly. "And I saw what it did to you. I heard you run down the stairs."

"I sat in the taxi to the station," Clara whispered, her chin trembling, "and I threw up in the gutter behind the terminal. I had never felt so small in my life. To stand in front of someone you've slept beside for five years, and realize that you have become invisible."

"You weren't invisible," Evan said softly. "The machine just cut the wire."

Clara reached out. Her fingers hovered over the Formica, hesitating for a fraction of a second, before she laid her ink-stained thumb against the side of his wrist.

Her skin was warm.

The contact sent no electric shock through his skull. No lost mornings on the ferry returned. No memories of her laugh bloomed in his temporal lobes. The past remained an empty, swept room.

Yet his pulse beneath her thumb slowed from a frantic, defensive flutter into a deep, steady rhythm. The phantom ache in his chest—the cold cavity that had whistled through his ribs since November—fell quiet.

"What now, Evan?" she asked, her voice barely carrying over the hum of the neon sign. "You don't have the memories. You don't know who I was when I was twenty-five. You don't know the jokes we had, or what we argued about on the train, or why we bought that stupid green mug."

"The mug was chipped," Evan murmured.

A tiny, wet laugh escaped her lips, breaking through the tears gathering at the corners of her eyes. "You remember that?"

"No," Evan said honestly. "I wrote it down in the notebook on Day 2 before the song vanished. I made a list of things to verify."

She pulled her hand back, wiping her eyes with the cuff of her cardigan, shaking her head at the sheer, ridiculous stubbornness of the man in front of her.

"Of course you did," she breathed. "A manifest. You turned me into a freight manifest."

"It was the only language I had," Evan said.

He picked up his black coffee, took a swallow, and looked through the glass at the dark, still water of the canal. The rain had slowed to a fine, misty spray, blurring the reflection of the streetlamps into long golden smears across the surface.

"I don't have the past, Clara," Evan said, turning back to face her. "And Dr. Miller said it's never coming back. If you want the man who stood on the ferry four years ago and promised to wait on the beach, he isn't here. He died on the gantry under a twenty-ton chain."

He looked at her dark brown eyes—clever, tired, beautiful, and completely new.

"All I have is a flat with an unlocked door, a steady day shift at the bonded cage, and an empty chair in the kitchen."

Clara looked at him across the table.

She took a slow sip of her orange pekoe tea, letting the caramel-colored liquid warm her throat. She set the mug down, picked up the paper napkin, and methodically folded it into a clean, sharp triangle.

"I'm keeping the studio in Rotterdam through the autumn," she said, her voice matter-of-fact, practical, stripped of sentimentality. "I have two more exhibitions under contract. One in Antwerp, one back here in October."

Evan nodded. "Good. The work deserves it."

"The commute from Rotterdam is three hours on the fast train," she continued, looking down at the folded napkin. "It runs twice a day. Friday afternoons and Monday mornings."

Evan's heart gave a single, quiet hitch. He didn't speak. He didn't push. He sat on his side of the booth, waiting for the perimeter she chose to set.

Clara raised her eyes.

"I don't want to live with a sentry, Evan. I will never live inside a fortress again."

"There is no fortress," Evan said. "The wall came down in November."

She looked at him for a long, searching moment, taking in the clean poplin shirt, the mended shoulder, the steady hands resting open on the yellowed table.

"My train back to the coast leaves tomorrow at noon," she said softly. "The Foundry has to be cleared by eleven."

She picked up her tea mug, holding it with both hands.

"Do you still know how to make toast without burning the crusts, or did that clinic take that too?"

Evan's mouth curved—a slow, unpracticed, genuine smile that reached his eyes for the first time in eight months.

"That wasn't in the seven categories," he said.

Clara leaned back against the red vinyl cushions, the tension draining out of her shoulders as she looked across the corner booth at the stranger she had loved for five years.

"Good," she said, raising her cup toward his. "Then pick me up at eleven, sentry. We'll start from there."

## CHAPTER 19

### THE THRESHOLD

Sunday arrived without an execution.

For six months, Sunday mornings had carried the phantom scent of ozone and cold linoleum—the weekly tick of a clock winding down to another amputation. But at nine in the morning, the light that broke across the kitchen floor was warm, pale gold, and completely indifferent to the calendar.

Evan boiled the kettle. He poured black coffee into his heavy mug, sat at the table, and ate two slices of dry toast with the crusts intact.

He didn't check a manifest. He didn't pace the boards.

At twenty to eleven, he put on a dark canvas work jacket over his white shirt, checked that his keys were in his pocket, and walked down the stairwell into the quiet Sunday hum of the textile quarter.

The Foundry Gallery was silent when he pushed through the brass doors at five minutes to eleven.

The wine flutes, the curator's plinth, and the clusters of suited patrons were gone. The white drywall stood bare, pocked with tiny gray anchor holes and pencil level marks where the thirty-two plates had hung the night before.

In the center of the polished concrete floor sat three wooden transport crates lined with closed-cell foam, and two heavy black portfolio folios with reinforced canvas corners.

Clara was kneeling beside the middle crate, wrapping a framed print in glassine paper, securing the edges with low-tack paper tape. She wore an old gray sweatshirt with the sleeves pushed past her forearms, her hair gathered into a loose knot behind her neck with a wooden drafting peg.

When the heavy doors hissed shut behind him, she didn't jump. She finished smoothing down the edge of the tape, tore it with her thumb, and looked up.

"You're five minutes early," she said.

"Traffic was light on the canal road," Evan replied, stopping six feet back.

She sat back on her heels, wiping a smudge of newsprint off her forearm with the palm of her hand. Her dark eyes were clearer than they had been in the diner booth—tired, but settled, carrying the quiet, steady focus of a printmaker at the end of a long press run.

"The heavy folio has the thirty-six-by-forty-eight proofs," she said, nodding toward the largest canvas case leaning against the brick pillar. "The reduction plates are packed in the center box. The rail freight service is picking the crates up tomorrow for Antwerp, but I need the two soft portfolios moved to the station lockers before twelve."

She looked at his left shoulder.

"Can you carry thirty pounds, or am I going to have to sign another hospital waiver?"

"The bone is knit," Evan said. "Tell me which one goes first."

They worked for twenty minutes in total, easy silence.

It was not the strained, brittle quiet of November, where every dropped spoon sounded like an indictment. It was the rhythmic, mechanical silence of two people who understood how to move cargo through tight doorways.

Evan did not rush. He did not heave the cases onto his shoulder to prove he was uninjured; he lifted from the knees, braced the canvas straps against his good side, and set them down on the handcart Clara had wheeled in from the loading dock.

She watched him out of the corner of her eye as she clicked the brass padlocks shut on the wooden crates.

"You move different," she said, pocketing the small brass keys.

Evan wiped his brow with the back of his wrist. "Different how?"

"You don't look like you're bracing for an explosion every time you pick up a box," she said, pushing a stray strand of hair behind her ear. "You used to walk into a room like the ceiling was four inches too low for your head."

"It felt like that," Evan said.

"And now?"

"The ceiling's where it always was," he said, holding the heavy glass doors open so she could maneuver the handcart out onto the cobblestones. "I was just standing on my own neck."

The sun was high and warm over Water Street, burning the morning damp off the dark granite pavers.

The walk to the central rail terminal took twenty minutes along the canal towpath. Evan pushed the handcart with his right hand, his left arm



swinging easy at his side, matching her shorter, measured stride without adjusting ahead.

They stopped at the corner of 4th and Elm to wait for the cross-town tram to pass.

The rusted iron shelter with the green corrugated awning was fifteen feet away, sitting under the midday sun. An elderly woman with a grocery pull-cart was sitting on the bench beneath the schedule board.

Clara stopped the cart. She looked at the iron awning, then turned her head to look at Evan.

The question was in her eyes, silent and raw: *Does anything come back?*

Evan looked at the green iron. He looked at the tram rails embedded in the black asphalt, shimmering slightly in the heat.

"Nothing," he said quietly. His voice carried no shame, no apology. Just the clean, unvarnished fact. "It's just a tram stop on Elm Street."

Clara watched his profile for three seconds. A small, faint breath slipped through her lips—not of disappointment, but of release. She reached down, touched the rubber grip of the handcart, and gave a single, firm nod.

"Good," she said. "The iron was rusting through anyway."

They crossed the tracks behind the ringing bell of the tram.

At the rail terminal, they checked the two portfolios into the climate-controlled baggage bay behind Track 4.

The digital departure board above the concourse clicked with a cascading mechanical chatter, flipping its white letters against black slats:

**INTER-CITY EXPRESS 408 / ROTTERDAM CS**

*Track 7 – Departs 12:14 PM – On Time*

Evan looked at the clock above the arrivals gate: 11:42 AM.

Thirty-two minutes.

The concourse was crowded with Sunday travelers—students hauling oversized backpacks, families arguing over train tickets, commuters clutching cardboard cups of coffee.

Clara stood near the iron pillar of Track 7, her overnight bag resting between her canvas shoes, her hands buried in the deep pockets of her moss-green cardigan.

"The Rotterdam studio lease runs until October," she said, her voice clear above the rumble of a diesel engine idling two tracks over. "I have eighty plates to pull for the Antwerp show before August."

"The bonded cage runs through the winter," Evan said. "Eight to four, Monday to Friday. No weekend turns."

She looked at him. "Do you have paper in the flat?"

"The black notebook," he said.

"Get a fresh one," she said, a faint, ironical spark touching the corner of her dark eyes. "Something without clinical grids and freight manifests. Something with blank pages."

She reached into her cardigan pocket, drew out an old brass latch key with a worn leather fob, and held it in her open palm.

The key to flat 4B.

Evan looked down at the metal. "You kept it?"

"I kept it in the bottom of my gouge roll in Rotterdam," she said, her fingers curling slightly over the brass. "Every time I wanted to convince myself that you were just a cruel bastard who threw five years away to spite me, I'd look at this key and remember how your face looked on Day 6. You looked like someone had shot you through the chest with an ice pick."

She reached out and took his right hand.

She turned his palm upward and pressed the brass key into his skin, closing his fingers over it with both of her hands.

"I don't need a key to an empty house, Evan," she whispered, her gaze locked on his face with an intensity that made the noise of the crowded station vanish into cold air. "If I come back in October, I'm not unlocking the door from the outside. You're going to have to open it."

Evan looked down at her ink-stained knuckles, then into the wet, dark brown of her eyes.

"The deadbolt isn't turned," he said softly. "It hasn't been turned since February."

A long, piercing whistle blew from the head of Track 7. The conductor in the blue serge uniform raised his yellow paddle, waving the passengers toward the open carriage doors.

Clara picked up her overnight bag with her left hand.

She stepped forward—one pace, closing the perimeter.

She didn't reach for his mouth. She didn't ask his scarred temporal lobes to pretend they knew the shape of her lips.

She leaned in, resting the side of her forehead against the thick, mended bone of his left collarbone for two long seconds. Her hair smelled of cedarwood, linseed oil, and the cold, salt wind blowing off the canal.

Evan raised his right arm, wrapping it slowly, deliberately around her shoulders, letting his hand rest flat against the rough knit of her sweater.

No static. No panic. No phantom alarms screaming in the dark.

Just two bodies standing on the concrete apron of Track 7, holding each other up against the noise of a world that didn't know their names.

She stepped back.

Her cheeks were dry. Her jaw was level.

"Don't lose the key, sentry," she said.

She turned, stepped up the metal stairs of the carriage, and disappeared into the corridor.

Evan stood on the platform as the heavy pneumatic doors hissed shut. The diesel engine surged with a deep, concussive roar, the steel wheels screeching against the rails as the train lurched forward, slowly gathering speed, pulling its silver flank past the platform until the red tail lamps vanished into the dark mouth of the canal tunnel.

Evan stood alone under the vaulted iron roof of the terminal.

He slipped the brass key into his trouser pocket, letting the cold metal rest against his thigh.

He walked out of the station, crossed the bridge over the sunny canal, and began the long walk back to the fourth floor of flat 4B, ready to write the zero entry into the clean slate.

SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

## CHAPTER 20

### DAY ZERO

Autumn returned to the city on the second Sunday of October.

It came with the same low, bruised clouds that had hung over the canal twelve months ago, the wind stripping yellow leaves from the alders and plastering them against the wet asphalt of Elm Street.

In flat 4B, the radiator was hot.

Evan had bled the air from the iron ribs three days prior, catching the dark water in a chipped enamel bowl, tightening the brass valve until the pipes hummed with a clean, steady hiss of steam. The kitchen tap did not drip. The linoleum was swept clean right into the corners.

On the drafting table in the spare alcove, the seven micro-cassettes sat in their plastic cases beside the silver Olympus recorder, their magnetic tape dark and still behind the little clear windows. Evan had not played them since November. Beside them lay the original black notebook, closed, its spine creased where the pages had been turned a hundred times.

Beside it lay a second notebook.

This one had no printed grid, no company header, and no dates stamped in the corners. It was bound in heavy, unbleached cotton canvas, filled with rough, deckled sketch paper that held the faint, sweet scent of pressed rag.

It lay open to the first page.

It was blank.

At three in the afternoon, the bells of the parish church two blocks away chimed three heavy, muffled strokes against the rain.

Evan stood in the kitchen, slicing a loaf of dark rye bread on a clean wooden board.

He was thirty-two now. The lump on his left collarbone had smoothed into a hard, permanent ridge, barely visible unless he rolled his shoulder back. His hands were dry, the yellow freight grease worked out of the skin after four months of warehouse inventory.

He set two ceramic mugs on the counter.

One was plain white, stained faintly brown along the inner rim.

The other was brand-new: heavy, unglazed stoneware the color of damp sand, bought from a ceramic stall at the harbor market. He set out the orange pekoe tea bag, the small pitcher of milk, and the sugar bowl with its stainless-steel spoon resting against the rim.

He did not measure the sugar.

He did not pour the milk.

He stood waiting in the warm room, listening to the rain tap against the living room glass.

At four o'clock, the floorboards on the fourth-floor landing creaked.

The sound was slow, heavy, followed by the dull *thud* of a canvas duffel bag being set down on the concrete outside door 4B.

Evan did not freeze. His chest did not tighten into a defensive fist. His heart beat with the slow, measured cadence of a man who had stopped running from the weather.

He wiped his hands on a clean tea towel, walked across the living room, and stopped two feet from the door.

He looked at the brass latch.

The deadbolt was drawn back, sitting open in its casing, exactly as it had been since the winter thaw. But the brass handle did not turn.

From the other side of the timber came two light, distinct raps of knuckles against the wood.

*Tap. Tap.*

She had not used the key. She was waiting for him to open the perimeter.

Evan reached out, took the brass lever in his right hand, depressed the latch, and pulled the door inward.

Clara stood on the landing.

She wore a dark wool overcoat damp with autumn drizzle, the collar turned up against her jaw. Her hair was cut blunt above her collarbones, a little longer than it had been in June, dark strands clinging to the pale skin of her temple. In her right hand, she carried a long, black cardboard drafting tube strapped with webbing.

She looked at him.

Her dark brown eyes—the color of wet river stones—scanned his face with that same sharp, forensic precision that had once terrified him. She took in the steady line of his mouth, the clean white cotton of his henley shirt, the open, relaxed drop of his left shoulder.

She saw no sentry.

She saw no empty house.



"The fast train was twenty minutes late at the canal bridge," she said, her voice slightly rough from the cold draft in the stairwell. "Signal failure."

"They're working on the switching gear at Bay 4," Evan said. "It always backs up the western approach."

She looked past his shoulder, into the flat.

She saw the warm yellow light spilling from the hallway lamp. She saw the clean floorboards, the radiator hissing softly beneath the sill, and the framed woodcut—*The First Night*—hanging in its plain black oak frame right across from the coat rack.

Her mouth softened into a faint, exhausted curve.

"You left the lock open," she said.

"Since February," Evan replied.

He stepped back three paces, clearing the threshold, his hands resting loose at his sides.

Clara picked up her duffel bag with her left hand, stepped over the brass weather-strip, and walked into the apartment.

The door clicked shut behind her on the simple spring latch.

She set her bag down by the baseboard, unbuttoned her damp coat, and hung it on the empty wooden peg beside his jacket. The flat filled immediately with that sharp, unmistakable signature: cedarwood, linseed oil, and the cold salt wind from across the North Sea.

She walked into the living room, stopped by the drafting table in the alcove, and looked down at the seven micro-cassettes sitting in the light.

She reached out, her finger tracing the plastic edge of tape **07 – THE CLEAN SLATE.**

"Did you listen to them again?" she asked quietly, not turning around.

"No," Evan said from the kitchen doorway. "The machine did what I paid it to do. Listening to the tapes won't make the stone turn back into bread."

Clara stood silent for a long moment, her shoulders lowering as she let out a breath she seemed to have held since June. She turned to face him, leaning back against the edge of the drafting table, her hands tucked into the pockets of her dark trousers.

She looked at him across the twelve feet of floorboards.

"Dr. Miller's clinic closed in August," she said.

Evan blinked. "Did it?"

"The regional health authority revoked their license for unlicensed clinical trials," she said, looking down at her plimsolls. "A formal audit found forty-two patients suffering from severe somatic dissociation. They sealed the files. The doctor moved to Zurich."

"It doesn't change anything," Evan said.

"No," she agreed, raising her dark eyes back to his. "It doesn't."

She walked into the small kitchen.

She saw the two mugs on the laminate counter: his plain white one, and the heavy, unglazed stoneware sitting beside the cold milk and the sugar bowl.

She reached out, picked up the ceramic mug, and turned it in her fingers, feeling the rough texture of the fired clay.

"This is new," she murmured.

"The mint-green one was chipped," Evan said.

A tiny, breathless laugh escaped her lips, her eyes crinkling at the corners. She set the mug down, picked up the orange pekoe bag, and dropped it into the steaming water.

She tipped three drops of milk from the pitcher, turning the dark tea into the exact color of caramel, and stirred in half a spoonful of sugar with a single, clear chime of steel against stone.

She set the spoon on the saucer.

She turned to face him, resting her lower back against the sink, holding the warm mug with both hands.

The room fell completely quiet. Outside, the rain tapped against the glass in a soft, irregular meter, but inside the four walls of flat 4B, the air was warm, clean, and still.

Clara looked at him across the narrow counter.

The humor slipped from her mouth, replaced by a vulnerability so raw, so completely stripped of armor, that it took the air right out of Evan's lungs.

"Do you remember me, Evan?" she asked.

Her voice didn't shake. It was a simple, terrifying question asked by a woman who had carried the weight of five years through European winters, standing in front of the man who had loved her enough to erase his own soul.

Evan looked into her eyes.

He searched the dark temporal corridors of his skull.

There was no sudden spark.

The tram stop under the rain did not return. The indie song on the vinyl was still just noise on a wire. The kiss on the fire escape remained a line of cold type in a book. The silversmith's promise had been swallowed by the gray tide, never to wash ashore again.

The clinical suppression had held. The past was an ash heap, dead and unrecoverable.

Evan looked at the woman standing in his kitchen—the ink stains on her fingers, the line of her collarbone, the smell of rain in her dark hair, the courage in her eyes that made the room feel vast and solid.

He stepped forward until there was only the breadth of the counter between them.

"No," Evan said softly.

He reached out, his hand open, his palm turned upward on the laminate.

"I don't remember you at all."

A single, silver tear crested Clara's lower lid, catching the yellow light of the stove bulb before rolling down into the corner of her mouth.

Evan held her gaze, his voice steady as iron, gentle as the rain on the sill:

"My name is Evan Vance. I work down at the bonded warehouse by the harbor. I don't keep a watch anymore, and the door stays unlocked."

He smiled—a slow, quiet, completely unburdened smile that reached into the marrow of his chest.

"I don't know who you are, Clara Lin. But if you have some time before the rain stops... I think I'd like to know you again."

Clara looked down at his open hand.

She looked at the calloused fingers, the blunt knuckles, the white scar across the thumb—empty of weapons, empty of ledgers, waiting on the wood.

She set her tea mug on the counter.

Slowly, deliberately, she reached across the laminate, laid her fingers into his open palm, and let her thumb curl over the back of his hand, their skin meeting warm and dry in the quiet room.

"All right, Evan," she whispered, her voice thick with tears that finally held no poison. "Let's start from here."

Later that night, after the tea was cold and the rain had settled into a fine mist over the quiet canal, Evan sat at the drafting table while Clara slept in the bedroom, the door left wide open to the dark hall.

He reached for the unbleached canvas notebook.

He dipped his steel nib into the black ink. He didn't write an inventory. He didn't make a list of things to verify, and he didn't calculate the cost of the firewood.

On the clean, unlined rag paper, beneath the warm yellow circle of the anglepoise lamp, he wrote the only entry that mattered:

**OCTOBER 11. DAY ZERO.**

*The seven days are over.*

*The house is not empty.*

SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

*Her name is Clara.*

*She takes her tea with half a teaspoon of sugar, and barely enough milk to cloud the surface.*

*I don't know what we were.*

*I don't need to know.*

*The tide went out, but the beach is still here.*

*And for the first time in my life, I am not afraid of the morning.*

SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU

fin.

## SEVEN DAYS BEFORE I FORGET YOU